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INBRIEF



GCC holds meeting on dengue prevention with 112 colleges

The Greater Chennai Corporation (GCC) held a review meeting with the principals and representatives of 112 colleges and higher educational institutions on Thursday to discuss measures to prevent dengue and other fevers. The meeting, chaired by Commissioner G.S. Sameeran, was held through videoconference at the Ripon Buildings. Institutions were instructed to remove unwanted materials and prevent water stagnation on campuses, particularly in containers, discarded tyres, flower pots, roof gutters, and construction areas. They were also asked to monitor student absences, report fever cases to the Corporation immediately, and coordinate with health officials. Students with fever were advised to seek immediate medical attention, consume adequate fluids, and avoid attending classes until recovery.

Text & Context and Health

Weekday features on *The Hindu* epaper (epaper.thehindu.com) carries explainers, special articles and quizzes. In the latest issue (September 25, Friday), the following articles are available:

- The unbearable burden of freedom newsth.live/surinderkolikase
- When cancer treatment is no longer working newsth.live/treatmentcancer

You can use your smartphone's inbuilt features to access these articles. If it's an Android phone, use Google Lens to read and tap the url to access an article. If it's an iPhone, use Live Text on camera to do the same.

Dengue, influenza in circulation; city hospitals see steady rise in fever cases

Doctors say the rise in fever cases remains in line with the seasonal trend typically observed from September to November. A doctor says that most flu cases are self-limiting but advises utmost care be given to pregnant women and the elderly

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Dengue and influenza viruses are currently in circulation, with a number of hospitals in the city reporting a steady flow of patients with fever, though doctors say the numbers remain in line with the seasonal trend. “Currently, both flu and dengue viruses are in circulation. Flu spreads from person to person, while dengue is a vector-borne infection. We need to deal with both the infections carefully. If a person has fever, they should look out for respiratory symptoms such as cold, cough, and throat pain. These are the primary symptoms of Influenza-Like Illness (ILI). If there is a high-grade fever with no respiratory symptoms but body pain and headache, it is a sign of dengue,” a senior government doctor said.

Hidden cases
Epidemiologically, if one case of dengue is notified in a particular area or village, it means there are hidden cases, he said, adding: “There is no need to test everyone, and persons

Dos & don'ts

Key precautions and advice from doctors

- **Avoid self-medication**
 - Basic blood investigation such as **Complete Blood Count (CBC)** is essential to assess and differentiate bacterial and viral etiology
 - **Platelet count** and hematocrit values (PCV) in CBC findings will provide vital clues in assessing dengue infection
- **Early treatment**

of influenza in elderly and pregnant mothers will prevent complications

- **Hydration** is important for fever management
- Give only **paracetamol** for fever as per the dose prescribed by doctors
- Seek medical help if a child has **vomiting**, is not taking adequate feeds, or is lethargic after the fever subsides
- Check plastic trays kept for flower pots and refrigerator trays for **water stagnation**
- Clean **overhead tanks** periodically

There are no official institution-wise figures on outpatients with fever

with typical symptoms can be treated appropriately based on a physician consultation. Laboratory tests can be initiated if doctors prescribe.” He said that in the case of flu, it is mostly self-limiting, but utmost care should be taken for elderly and pregnant women. “ILI can lead to Severe Acute Respiratory Infection and

people could land in Acute Respiratory Distress Syndrome. Early treatment is important for flu-like symptoms. For dengue, a basic blood test – Complete Blood Count – will give us clues, especially a drop in the platelet count. So, with two viruses in circulation, which happens naturally during this season, people should be pre-

pared and alert,” he said. However, there are no official institution-wise figures on fever outpatients or admissions. Authorities of at least two government hospitals in Chennai said the number of fever cases were not rampant and admissions for fever had not increased. In another hospital, senior doctors said all beds in the fever ward were full, and that the patients were recovering.

Seasonal trend
S. Chandrasekar, Professor and Head, Department of Medicine and Critical Care Services, Government Stanley Medical College Hospital, said that at present, the situation was not alarming and the rise in fever cases was in line with the expected seasonal trend typically observed from September to November. “A mild variant of flu is also in circulation. Dengue cases slowly peak after rainfall in mid-November and usually settle by February-end every year. There is a small excess of cases this year. Many persons, especially adolescents/teenagers, are being referred late, and with complications such as ca-

pillary leak syndrome on the fifth or sixth day of illness. We are closely watching the situation. It is important to know the warning symptoms of dengue,” he said. At Sankar Kamakoti CHILDS Trust Hospital, medical director Janani Sankar said they were seeing a lot of dengue and influenza A cases as well as a few Respiratory Syncytial Virus infections. “The cases are quite rampant. Our beds are full. We are seeing children with dengue, respiratory infections, wheezing, and bronchiolitis. Some children with dengue are requiring admissions for 24 to 48 hours, but none with complications,” she said. Dr. Sankar said parents should ensure there are no water collections in and around their homes. As dengue virus is transmitted by a day-biting mosquito, schools must ensure that they take mosquito control measures. “If a child is dull after a fever subsides, they should seek medical help. The warning signs of dengue are abdominal pain, vomiting, bleeding, drowsiness, and refusal to take feeds,” she said.

Lizard found in food served to students, action taken against cooks

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

After a lizard was found in the food meant for the Chief Minister's Breakfast Scheme at the Kottaiyur Middle School in Kadam-bathur block on Thursday, Tiruvallur Collector S. Kavitha relieved the two woman cooks, Arthi and Dhanalakshmi, of duty. She also directed that action be initiated against the school headmaster and teacher, and the block development officer in-charge of the scheme. Sources said the cooks noticed the lizard while transferring *rava kichadi* to smaller utensils. Since 40 of the 54 children had consumed a portion of the food by then, the children were immediately made to drink salt water and vomit. They were then taken to the Tiruvallur Medical College Hospital, where they underwent a check-up and were later sent home. One girl student was admitted to the hospital with diarrhoea. The Collector, who visited the school and the hospital, said the incident happened because the utensils containing the food were not covered properly.

Minister Anand launches State-wide drive to plant one crore palm seeds

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Tamil Nadu government, in collaboration with non-governmental organisations, has launched a State-wide drive to plant one crore palm seeds. The initiative is aimed at strengthening the bunds of waterbodies and preventing soil erosion. Minister for Rural Development-Panchayat Raj and Water Resources N. Anand inaugurated the drive at Devariyaambakkam village panchayat in Kancheepuram district on Thursday. The drive will be carried out in 37 districts, excluding the Nil-



Minister N. Anand inaugurating the drive in Kancheepuram on Thursday.

giris, in collaboration with Green Needa, ExNoRa International, National Social Service, and National Cadet Corps. About one lakh NSS students will participate in the drive.

The seeds will be sourced from the Palm Seeds Banks established in 100 colleges and planted along the bunds of waterbodies across the State, according to a press release. The initiative aims at increasing the number of palm trees in the State to strengthen the bunds of waterbodies, support groundwater recharge, and enhance the production of value-added palm products. Kancheepuram Collector D. Sneha; Uthiramerur MLA J. Murnathinam; president of ExNoRa International S. Senthur Paarj; and chief coordinator of Green Needa M. Rajavelu took part in the event on Thursday.

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

An alert Railway Protection Force (RPF) constable rescued a 69-year-old passenger, who was dragged by a train after falling into the gap between the train and the platform, at Guindy railway station on Thursday evening. The incident occurred around 5.30 p.m. when a Vil-

The passenger sustained an injury to his left leg and the RPF personnel administered first-aid

upuram-Chennai Beach train started departing from Platform 1. The passenger, Mohammed Elias, reportedly lost his footing while attempting to board the train and fell into the gap.

He was dragged for nearly 50 metres as the train moved. Constable Narayan Singh of Mambalam RPF, who was deployed at the Guindy station, noticed the passenger and immediately alerted the railway staff. Once the train was stopped, the constable pulled Elias to safety. Elias sustained a bleeding injury to his left leg. The RPF personnel administered first-

aid and called a 108 ambulance. He was given further medical attention inside the ambulance before returning home. The incident resulted in a four-minute delay to Train No. 66046, which remained at Guindy station from 5.30 p.m. to 5.34 p.m. Railway authorities advised passengers not to board or alight from trains once they start moving.

De-addiction programme launched at Puzhal prison

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

A comprehensive de-addiction and rehabilitation programme for drug offenders, ‘PAYANAM’ (Positive Awareness Yielding Against Narcotics Addiction Movement), was launched as a pilot project at Central Prison-II in Puzhal on Thursday. The programme was inaugurated by the Director-General of Police (Prisons and Correctional Services), Sandeep Rai Rathore. Designed to facilitate de-addiction, behavioural change, rehabilitation and social reintegration, PAYANAM, will provide inmates with counselling, psychological support, therapeutic interventions, life-skills training and rehabilitation assistance. Addressing the participants, Mr. Rathore said drug addiction affected not only individuals but also inmates’ families and society. The correctional system, he said, should therefore extend beyond custody to treatment, reform, rehabilitation and reintegration.

THE HINDU

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New Delhi - Rs. 15/-;
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Centre for Railway Information Systems
Chennai
Tender No. 01265217A
Tender Title: For Procurement of Handholding Support Manpower and BI Tool (Qlik) for 1 years for IR-NIYANTRAC project.
Date of Closing: 15.10.2026 (Thursday) 15:30 hrs. Tender Documents may be downloaded from Website www.iireps.gov.in. For future modification/extensions please see www.iireps.gov.in.

Centre For Railway Information Systems
Chennai
TENDER NOTICE
Tender No: 01265253
Tender Title: Procurement of Maintenance Service-Help desk Operation-Handholding Engineers-System software's and other items for Post implementation Support of TDMS Project for DCCIL for 3 years. Date of Closing: 15.10.2026 (Thursday) 15:30 hrs. Tender Documents may be downloaded from Website www.iireps.gov.in. For future modifications/extension please see www.iireps.gov.in

RATE CONTRACT FOR FACILITATING LAND ACQUISITION

Tender Notice No. CON/2026/AUG/06. Open tender through e-Tendering system is invited from experienced and reputed contractor(s)/firm(s) for the following works: **Tender No. CE/CON/SUR/LA/2026/07. Name of work:** Rate Contract for facilitating Land Acquisition for Railway projects of Northeast Frontier Railway (Construction) in NFR Jurisdiction for a period of 3 years. **Approx. value:** ₹17,61,15,690/-. **Earnest Money:** ₹35,22,300/- **Date & Time of closing of tender:** At 14.30 hrs. & opening at: 15.30 hrs. on 13-10-2026. The complete information and tender document of above e-Tender will be available at www.iireps.gov.in

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PERSONAL

CHANGE OF NAME

I, Malathy S, wife of Thiru Jothesh, born on 15th February 1987 (District of Birth: Chennai), residing at No. 475, N.S.K. Nagar, Arumbakkam, Chennai-600106, shall henceforth be known as MALATHY

I, R Jothesh, son of Thiru Ramachandran, born on 27th March 1984 (District of Birth: Chennai), residing at No. 475, N.S.K. Nagar, Arumbakkam, Chennai-600106, shall henceforth be known as JOTHESH

I, Vigneshwaran N S/o P Navaneetha Krishnan, DOB: 04-07-1991 Residing at 51, 1st Floor, 1st Main, 4th Cross, Vignana Nagar, Bengaluru - 560 075. Shall Henceforth be known as VIGNESHWARAN KORAPATI

I, David Paul, S/o Sebastian S. Dob 05-04-1990, residing at 15 Annai Indra Nagar 2nd Annex Thiruninravur 602 024. Shall henceforth be known as David Paul S.

I, OLD Given name: Sedhu,with Old Surname:Angappan, S/o A.Mohan, R/o 51, kumaran st., Vivekananda nagar, Nesapakkam, Chennai have changed my name to New Given Name Sedhu Angappan with New Surname Mo-han for all purposes Vide affidavit dated 22.09.2026

I, Booshanam, W/o Late 1314284 Rank: Ex-SAPPER NALLAMUTHU R/o: # 89, 2nd Main, Nehru Nagar, Hosur, Krishnagiri District, Tamilnadu want to change name of my dependant from BABY STELLA to SHEEBA STELLA N Vide Affidavit sworn before Sub Divisional Magistrate (E) & Sub-Collector Hosur dt: 03/09/2026

I, E Subamathi spouse of JC-332437A Sub Maj Balasubramanian J residing at 20 Keelathuru Nallamgudi (Vill), Nannilam (PO), Thiruvavur - 610105 (Birth place address as per Aadhar) & presently residing with spouse A-16, Vikas Court Apartments, Bharathi Nagar, Periyar Street, Ganapathy, Coimbatore have changed my name from E Subamathi to Subamathi E vide affidavit no FG 352900 dated 29 Jul 2026 before Notary N Siva Bharathi, Chennai

PERSONAL

CHANGE OF NAME

I, KAVITA Sharma, spouse of Dev Kumar Sharma, resident of House no 4, Gandhi road, Mittanmali, Avadi, Chennai 600055 have changed my name from Kavita Sharma to Kavita Kumari vide affidavit dated 03 sep 26 before Notary public, Chennai

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AVADI INDUS Land 4.12 Acre 10K Sq Bldg Corner 50KV Rs.29Cr 9849888660

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PUZUTHIVAKKAM MRTS 4000sf Rs. 16000/sf, 1300sf Rs.10500/sf. 9444927746

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COMMERCIAL

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INBRIEF



MoU signed for establishing Flammability Learning Lab

Anna University's Madras Institute of Technology (MIT) Campus recently signed an MoU with Boeing India for establishing a Flammability Learning Laboratory. The proposed facility is envisioned as a globally unique laboratory and the first dedicated academic facility of its kind for flammability research, testing, and training within an academic institution. A press release said the agreement, signed on September 22, would provide MIT students with opportunities to gain practical skills in flammability science and safety. The laboratory is also expected to strengthen academic-industry collaboration and support research, training, and innovation in aerospace flammability.

Offices of Metrowater will remain open this Sunday

Chennai Metrowater offices across the city will function on September 27, from 10 a.m. to 3.30 p.m., for the payment of water and sewer tax and charges for the first half of this fiscal year. A press release said consumers must pay their water and sewer tax and charges by September 30 to avoid surcharges. Cash counters at all area offices and headquarters will be open on Sunday. Residents may also make payments through online banking, credit and debit cards, UPI, and QR codes, the release said.

Corporation prepares DPRs for upgrading bus route and interior roads at ₹150 crore

The project is a part of the government's announcement to improve 360 km of bus route, interior roads in city at an estimated cost of ₹300 cr.; works will be taken up before the onset of monsoon

STORIES FROM THE ROAD

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Greater Chennai Corporation (GCC) has prepared detailed project reports (DPRs) for upgrading 160 km of damaged bus route roads and interior roads, covering 780 roads at an estimated cost of ₹150 crore, and has sent the proposals to the State government for administrative approval. The proposals are being processed under the Chief Minister's Infrastructure Development and Urban Mission (CMIUDM).

The first phase covers 45.13 km of 66 bus route roads and 114.87 km of 714 interior roads across all 15 zones. The projects are part of the State Government's 2026-27 announcement to upgrade 360 km of bus route and interior roads in Chennai at an estimated cost of ₹300 crore,



For a smooth ride: The proposals cover 45.13 km of 66 bus route roads and 114.87 km of 714 interior roads across all 15 zones in the city. R. RAGU

Commissioner G.S. Sameeran announced on Thursday.

The works are being taken up based on the Chief Minister's announcement under Rule 110 of the Tamil Nadu Legislative Assembly.

The project estimates will be examined by the Tamil Nadu Urban Finance and Infrastructure Development Corporation (TUFIDCO), following which

the approval process will be taken forward. "DPRs are prepared and being appraised by TUFIDCO and will be presented to the State-level approval committee for CMIUDM on September 29, 2026," he added.

According to GCC, tenders will be called immediately after necessary approvals, and the road improvement works will

be taken up before the onset of Northeast monsoon.

The GCC currently maintains 488 bus route roads covering 418.56 km and 35,978 interior roads covering 5,653.89 km. Works including road construction and improvement, footpaths and junction improvements are being carried out through the Corporation's Bus Route Roads Department.



GCC allocates first instalment of Ward Development Fund

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Ahead of the Greater Chennai Corporation's (GCC) council meeting this month, the civic body has allocated ₹60.60 crore as the first instalment of the 2026-27 Ward Development Fund.

Each of the 200 councillors and two special councillors will receive ₹30 lakh. According to GCC, the funds can be used for road and drainage works, rainwater harvesting, and other monsoon preparedness measures. The works

must be carried out in accordance with the Tamil Nadu Transparency in Tenders Act, 1998 and Rules, 2000.

Notably, during the previous council meeting on August 28, councillors, clad in black, expressed dissatisfaction over the non-disbursal of the "councillor's fund."

In 2022, ₹35 lakh was the maximum amount a councillor could spend under this scheme, which increased to ₹40 lakh the following year, ₹50 lakh in 2024, and finally ₹60 lakh in 2025.

Tender for Section V of Chennai Peripheral Ring Road cancelled

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Tamil Nadu Road Development Company (TNRDC) has annulled the tender floated for the construction of the Singaperumal Koil to Poonjeri (Section V) of the Chennai Peripheral Ring Road project citing "administrative reasons."

The work for the contractor entailed the design

and construction of the approximately 27-km long stretch. This section of the 133.64-km access-controlled six-lane dual carriageway, with two-lane service lanes on either side, is being constructed with external funding assistance to the tune of 49,847 million Japanese Yen (₹3,009.85 crore) from Japan International Cooperation Agency (JICA). Section I of this project

is being implemented by TNRDC with external funding assistance from JICA to the tune of 40,074 million Japanese Yen.

Sections II and III are being implemented with external funding assistance from Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank (AIIB) and OPEC Fund for International Development to the tune of \$478 million.

Section IV of CPRR has already been completed.

The preparation of a detailed project report (DPR) is in progress for the upgradation of Section IV as an access-controlled road.

Port connectivity

The ₹17,958.39 crore project, which aims to improve connectivity for vehicles from the southern parts of the State to the Ennore and Kattupalli ports, will also have an Intelligent Transport System (ITS).



The tender entailed design and construction of an approximately 27-km long stretch from Singaperumal Koil to Poonjeri.

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Govt. doctors' association seeks CM's intervention in DME appointment

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Democratic Tamil Nadu Government Doctors' Association has sought the intervention of the Chief Minister and Health Minister for immediate

intervention in the appointment of a new Director of Medical Education (DME).

In a letter to the Chief Minister, the association alleged that there could be attempts to bypass the existing guidelines for eligi-

bility. It appealed to the Chief Minister and Health Minister for immediate intervention to ensure genuineness in the appointment of DME and to follow the existing selection system in a fair manner.

Timings			
CHENNAI			
FRIDAY, SEP. 25			
RISE	05:58	SET	18:03
RISE	17:07	SET	04:34
SATURDAY, SEP. 26			
RISE	05:58	SET	18:03
RISE	17:45	SET	05:24
SUNDAY, SEP. 27			
RISE	05:58	SET	18:02
RISE	18:25	SET	06:16

Chennai Weather		
	max	min
Tiruvallur	36	26
Chennai Airport	36	27
Chennai City	36	28

Chennai Airport Today
35°C The weather will be warm and windy. Night will be comfortable. Mostly dry weather to prevail.

Chennai Airport Tomorrow
36°C Morning will be comfortable. Day will be very warm. Night will be comfortable. Dry weather to prevail.

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CINEMA ♦ ARTS ♦ EVENTS

MUSIC DANCE DRAMA

Goethe-Institut/Max Mueller Bhavan Chennai
Invites you to MULBERRY QUINTET | 16 OCTOBER 2026, 6:30 PM | GOETHE-INSTITUT CHENNAI, 4 Rutland Gate, 5th Street, Chennai. An Evening of Western Classical Music — featuring works by Bach, Mozart, Beethoven & Brahms, alongside Indian compositions.. All are welcome!

MISCELLANEOUS

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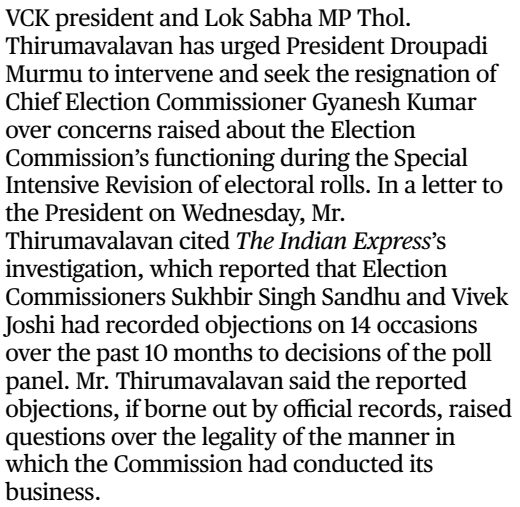
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PUBLIC NOTICE

**ENHANCEMENT OF STATUTORY WAGE CEILING UNDER EPF SCHEME
FROM Rs. 15,000 To Rs. 25,000**

(Effective Date: 17.09.2026)

The Union Cabinet, chaired by the Hon'ble Prime Minister Shri Narendra Modi, has approved the comprehensive proposal of the Ministry of Labour & Employment to enhance the wage ceiling for mandatory coverage under the Employees' Provident Fund Organisation (EPFO) from Rs.15,000 to Rs.25,000 per month. This historic decision is poised to bring more than 51 lakh additional employees into the formal statutory social security safety net, significantly strengthening welfare protection for India's workforce.

At present, fresh employees entering formal employment at a wage above Rs.15,000 per month were not mandatorily covered under the EPF framework, often remaining deprived of statutory provident fund, pension, and insurance coverage. Raising the ceiling to Rs.25,000 brings the vital Rs.15,000-Rs.25,000 wage band into the mainstream social security architecture.

Shri Rajeev Kumar, Regional PF Commissioner-I, EPFO Regional Office Sriperumbudur, highlighted that this landmark reform will broadly expand universal access to retirement savings, pension protection under the Employees' Pension Scheme (EPS), and life insurance benefits under the Employees' Deposit Linked Insurance Scheme (EDLI). He noted that the revision aligns statutory contributions and the pensionable wage ceiling realistically with prevailing industry compensation structures.

Presently, EPFO Regional Office Sriperumbudur administers provident fund benefits for approximately 5,00,000 members. The enhancement gives major impetus to employment formalisation, worker retention, and long-term retirement security. Automatic inclusion reinforces the tenet that formal employment must invariably provide portable and assured statutory protection. For employers, wider coverage directly fosters workforce retention, heightened morale, and industrial productivity.

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◆ This financial relief is extended for 02 years in non-manufacturing sectors and up to 04 years for manufacturing units, catalysing large-scale job creation.

This reform stands as a pivotal milestone towards engineering an inclusive, robust, and future-ready social security infrastructure, guaranteeing that citizen welfare expands in tandem with national economic expansion as India marches towards Viksit Bharat@2047.

Ref: EPFO/RO/SPB/D2626/09

Issued in Public Interest by Regional Office, Sriperumbudur.

Date: 21.09.2026

(Regional PF Commissioner-I)

EPFO Regional Office, Sriperumbudur.



GOVERNMENT OF INDIA

**Ministry of Education
Department of Higher Education
Technical Section – I**

**Invitation of Applications
for the post of Director, IIT Mandi**

Applications are invited for appointment to the post of Director of Indian Institute of Technology Mandi. The Director of an IIT is the academic and administrative head of the Institution. He/she is expected to have a minimum of 5 years' administrative experience and leadership qualities to head an Institute of National importance. The candidate/ person should be a Ph.D. with first class or equivalent at the preceding degree, preferably in a branch of Engineering. In exceptional cases, candidates with Science, Mathematics or Management degrees may be considered. He/she should have an outstanding academic record throughout and a minimum of 10 years teaching experience as a Professor in a reputed Engineering or Technology Institute or University and should have guided Ph.D. students. The applicant should preferably be less than 60 years of age on the last date of receipt of the applications. The post carries a fixed pay of Rs. 2,25,000/- (Revised) per month, with allowances as per rules.

2. Interested individuals may apply giving their detailed resume in the prescribed format clearly bringing out research, teaching, industry-academia collaborations and administrative achievements, along with a two-page justification in support of their candidature, a two-page vision statement for the institution and contact details of at least two distinguished individuals well acquainted with their work. The application typed in the prescribed format along with enclosures may be sent by Registered/Speed Post to **The Under Secretary (TS.1), Department of Higher Education, Ministry of Education, US-01, Work Hall No. 21108, First Floor, Kartavya Bhawan-2, New Delhi-110001** so as to reach the Ministry on or before **31st October, 2026**. The detailed advertisement and the format of application is available on the website.

URL: <https://www.dohe-education.gov.in/static/uploads/2026/09/053677fcc37904470df4829673b9fcd7.pdf>

From Page One

Veeramani case: two IPS officers shunted out

But the development came against the backdrop of Tamil Nadu Congress Committee Scheduled Caste department leader Ranjan Kumar revealing that as early as November 2024, he had given a complaint about the crime to Mr. Kannan when he was the Additional Commissioner of Police, Chennai. Mr. Kumar said the officer had told him that he would deal with the complaint after conferring with Mr. Arun, the then Commissioner of Police.

‘Anonymous letter’

However, only last year did the police register a First Information Report (FIR) in the case, claiming that they had received an anonymous letter and pen drive (allegedly containing evidence of the sexual abuse) through a representative of a non-governmental organisation.

According to the Home Department order, DGP (Training) Rajeev Kumar will hold the additional charge of the Police Academy and R.V. Ramya Bharati, IGP, West Zone, will hold the additional charge of Commissioner of Police, Coimbatore.

INBRIEF



BJP condemns ‘contamination’ of breakfast for students

BJP Tamil Nadu president Nainar Nagenthiran criticised the TVK-led government over alleged instances of contamination of breakfast meant for students of government schools in Chengalpattu and Tiruvallur. Referring to media reports on the hospitalisation of students owing to food contamination, Mr. Nagenthiran said children’s lives were put at risk in the name of the breakfast scheme. He pointed to the alleged lack of quality checks and hygiene audits. He called for severe action against the officials and contractors responsible for these incidents.



CM congratulates Indian team on winning Asian Games silver

Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay on Thursday congratulated the Indian team for winning the silver medal in the 4x400-metre relay event at the Asian Games being held in Japan. In a post on X, Mr. Vijay said it was a matter of great honour and pride that two of the four members of the team were from Tamil Nadu. In recognition of the achievements of Vidhya Ramraj and Vishal T.K., the Tamil Nadu government will provide an incentive of ₹50 lakh under the Sports Development Authority of Tamil Nadu’s ‘ELITE Sportsperson Scheme’, he said.

It is for Parliament to enact law against legislators who resign and re-contest same seat, says court

Mohamed Imranullah S.
CHENNAI

It is for Parliament to enact a law against the practice of legislators resigning, only to shift their political allegiance and re-contest the same seat in the resulting bypolls, the Madras High Court said on Thursday. First Division Bench of Chief Justice Sushrut Arvind Dharmadhikari and Justice G. Arul Murugan refused to direct the Election Commission (EC) to recover the cost of the bypolls from the legislators who had resigned, or disqualify the resignees from contesting elections for five years. The judges dismissed a PIL petition filed by Chennai-based advocate K. Suthan, who had sought a

direction to the EC to disqualify legislators who resign without a compelling reason, and to stall the bypolls in Madurantakam and Dharapuram Assembly constituencies until the disposal of his main plea. “The Election Commission has no free-standing power, either under Article 324 of the Constitution or otherwise, to add conditions/bar to the existing list of disqualifications; and if the Commission itself has no such power, this Court cannot, through a writ of mandamus, confer that power upon it,” they said. The court recalled that the EC had, in its 2004 proposal on electoral reforms, recommended the collection of byelection expenditure deposit from candi-

ACP Yasmin, who first handled Veeramani case, also transferred

Ms. Yasmin, the ACP, Koyambedu, has been placed on ‘vacancy reserve’ on administrative grounds. The police start probing extortion charges

R. Sivaraman
CHENNAI

Amid mounting allegations of mishandling of the case in which octogenarian business magnate R. Veeramani of Gem Granites has been accused of sexually abusing minor girls, the Police Department on Thursday shifted out Assistant Commissioner of Police (ACP) M.A. Yasmin, who was among those who had initially handled the case. Ms. Yasmin, who was serving as the ACP, Koyambedu, had been placed on ‘vacancy reserve’ on administrative grounds, sources said.

Meanwhile, the Greater Chennai police have started inquiries into allegations that some political functionaries, who had come to know about the case, extorted money from the businessman. On Wednesday, Congress second-line leader Ranjan Kumar alleged that he had complained about the crime to the police as early as in November 2024. He also claimed to have learnt about the crime when Shanthi (now arraigned as co-accused) sought his help to mediate with Tamilaga Makkal Munnetra Kazhagam lead-



Businessman R. Veeramani’s alleged accomplice Shanthi emerging from a special court in Chennai on Thursday. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

er John Pandian over a dispute. However, on Thursday, Mr. Pandian alleged that Shanthi and Mr. Kumar had contacted him and asked him to get ₹20 crore from Mr. Veeramani. “Kumar approached me two-and-a-half years ago, through a political functionary, claiming that a family dispute involving Mr. Veeramani had to be settled. We met at Taj Hotel. Kumar came with a woman named Shanthi. They asked me to threaten Mr. Veeramani and get the money. I told them that I would not do any such thing, and left in anger,” he said. In a related development, the POCSO Special Court allowed the police to take Shanthi and her hus-

band Mahendra Simhan into custody for interrogation for three days. The police said they needed to question them based on the information obtained from Veeramani, and ascertain how many minor girls were allegedly victimised; how long the abuse continued; and who else was involved. A few English news channels and some users on social media shared photographs and video clips of Veeramani in the company of a girl. The police warned that the sharing of such pictures of a minor was a criminal offence under Section 23 (2) of the POCSO Act, and would warrant legal action. “Hence, it is requested not to share any such information in public. Anyone having evidence related to this case may produce it to the Greater Chennai Police,” the police said. In Salem, a team of the Central Crime Branch conducted searches at two places linked to Veeramani. Around 10.30 a.m., the four-member team from Chennai came to a granite office at Kandampatti Butterfly Flyover. Likewise, the CCB conducted searches in a house at State Bank Colony near Five Roads for more than three hours.

Child rights activists urge Juvenile Justice Committee to probe sexual abuse case

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Child rights activists have urged the Juvenile Justice and POCSO Committee to conduct an inquiry into the alleged sexual abuse of children by Gem Granites owner R. Veeramani. In a letter to the committee, the Tamil Nadu Child Rights Watch said, “The circumstances reported in relation to this case raise questions about whether vulnerable children can receive equal protection of law when allegations involve a person possessing substantial financial, social, institutional, and political influence.” Contending that information on the abuse had allegedly reached the police in 2025, they questioned the evidence-preservatation measures undertaken at the earliest stage at which the authorities became aware of the allegations. They also raised concerns that the social and economic standing of the accused may have had a bearing on the manner in which the matter was initially investigated. “The credibility of the justice system depends upon demonstrating that the social, economic or political status of an accused person can’t determine the quality, speed or direction of a child sexual abuse investigation,” an ac-

tivist said. They also stressed that the investigation should examine whether there are other children or persons who may have been subjected to similar forms of abuse or exploitation. “We request the Committee to consider directing or recommending an independent, impartial, and comprehensive inquiry into the handling of the case, and that the investigation be directly monitored by a sitting judge of the Madras High Court,” the representation said. PMK demands action Meanwhile, PMK president Anbumani Ramadoss demanded a speedy probe and stringent action against those involved in the alleged sexual abuse. In a statement issued on Thursday, Dr. Anbumani said the reports emerging in connection with the case involving the businessman were shocking. He alleged that attempts had earlier been made to protect those involved, despite the availability of evidence of sexual abuse. He said all those involved should face stringent action, irrespective of their status. If required, the sections of the case filed under the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act should be altered based on the findings of the investigation, he said.

DMK regime did not shield anyone: Stalin

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Former Chief Minister and DMK president M.K. Stalin on Thursday said it was reprehensible on the part of a certain group to spread false allegations against the DMK in connection with the handling of the child sexual assault case involving industrialist and Gem Granites founder Veeramani. He said no order was given during the DMK regime to protect anyone in the case. In a statement, he said Veeramani had been arrested, and anyone who had connived with him or sought to protect him should not be spared, even if they held high positions. “This is the DMK’s stand. The outcome of the case should deter anyone from committing such crimes. It is my wish as a leader of the party, a head of a family, and a man with a conscience,” he said. Mr. Stalin said proper action had been taken in cases involving crimes against women and girls; chargesheets had been filed; and the accused had been punished by the courts. He said the erstwhile DMK government had never sought to shield anyone, as was allegedly being done by the TVK government now. “Even though affected women have filed complaints against a TVK MLA and district secretaries, no action has been taken, and there have been attempts to reach a compromise,” he alleged.

Four killed as car rams omni bus

The Hindu Bureau
PERAMBALUR

Four occupants of a car were killed when their vehicle rammed an omni bus on the Tiruchi-Chennai National Highway at Thuraimangalam in Perambalur in the early hours of Thursday. A group of seven persons were returning to Chennai from Mudukulathur in Ramanathapuram after attending a wedding when the fatal accident occurred around 2.30 a.m. Four persons died while three others were injured. The police identified the deceased as R. Prabhakaran, 30, of Rasikulam in Ramanathapuram, and K. Kaleeswaran, 25, K. Su-

rya, 35, and her husband A. Karthi, 38, from Oriyaval in Ramanathapuram. They had visited Ramanathapuram to attend the wedding of Karthi’s younger brother, police sources said. Prabhakaran and Kaleeswaran were killed on the spot. Karthi succumbed to injuries at the Perambalur Government Hospital, while Surya died later at the Mahatma Gandhi Memorial Government Hospital in Tiruchi, where she had been admitted for further treatment. The 34 passengers travelling on the omni bus from Thoothukudi to Chennai proceeded to their destination on an alternative bus arranged for them, police sources said.

Senior professors to oversee 11 State varsities without V-Cs, says Minister

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Eleven State universities without Vice-Chancellors will soon have senior professors overseeing their administration, Higher Education Minister P. Viswanathan said on Thursday. After inaugurating the two-day Edu-Tech Expo organised by the Confederation of Indian Industry (CII) in Chennai, he said convenor committees functioning at 13 State universities would obtain a panel of senior professors from their Syndicates and select one among them to act as the Vice-Chancellor in-charge with the necessary powers. The process had been completed at Ma-



Spotlight on innovation: Minister P. Viswanathan visits stalls at the Edu-Tech Expo in Chennai on Thursday. B. VELANKANNI RAJ

nonmaniam Sundaranar University and Alagappa University, and the other universities would follow suit, he said. On the appointment of Vice-Chancellors, Mr. Viswanathan said that since the matter was pending before the High Court and the Supreme Court, it could not be discussed. Mr. Viswanathan said

The expo features innovative products and technologies from participating institutions, and is aimed at providing students of engineering, polytechnic, and arts and science colleges with exposure to emerging technologies and industry requirements.

If there can be housewives, there can be house husbands also: HC

The Hindu Bureau
MADURAI

“If there can be housewives, there can be house husbands also. Let this become a new normal. We are of the view that this would help preserve the institution of marriage and family. The expression ‘home maker’ is gender-neutral,” the Madurai Bench of the Madras High Court has said. A Division Bench of Justices G.R. Swaminathan and M.D. Sumathi said, “Unlike modern western societies, in Bharatiya culture, it is the family and not the individual that is the foundational unit.” Traditionally, the responsibility of raising financial resources rested on

the husband, the wife took care of the domestic front. Both roles are entitled to equal respect. This position has been changing over the last half a century. Women are also increasingly becoming career oriented, the court said. “We note that this is taking a toll on many relationships, particularly in the IT sector. Marriage is not proving to be a win-win proposition for career women. Since such women see marriage as an impediment to their career prospects, they choose to skip it altogether. The number of unmarried women is on the rise. The situation can probably be remedied if husbands would opt to be home makers,” the judges said.

“Until a while ago, women would happily introduce themselves as housewives. These days, they put on an embarrassed look and say, ‘just a housewife’, even though there is nothing to be embarrassed about,” the court said. The bench was hearing civil miscellaneous appeals filed by a doctor couple. It said the relationship between the parties had broken down beyond repair. “The marriage that was solemnised between the parties is dissolved by a decree of divorce by mutual consent. The decree of divorce will come into force only upon the fulfilment of the financial obligations undertaken by the man before us,” the court said.

INBRIEF



Police issue formal orders for SIT in CMRL payoffs case

The police in Keralam have issued formal orders appointing a Special Investigation Team (SIT) led by Crime Branch Superintendent of Police (SP) P. Vikraman to inquire into corruption allegations against Leader of the Opposition Pinarayi Vijayan, his daughter T. Veena, former Minister P.A. Mohamed Riyas and his associates in the CMRL-Exalogic pay-off case. It will be supervised by the Additional Director General of Police (ADGP), Crime Branch.

Karnataka govt. announces one-time aid for farmers

The Karnataka government on Thursday announced a one-time relief of ₹2,500 to farmers across the State in view of crop losses due to drought conditions. The government also announced a moratorium of 12 months for loan repayment. All farm loans will get an extension between 36 months and 60 months, based on the tenure. The relief package is estimated to cost the exchequer ₹1,250 crore and will benefit about 45 lakh to 50 lakh farmers.

Telangana govt. forms panel to probe land irregularities

The Telangana government has constituted a committee to inquire into alleged land irregularities in several villages across the State, including properties linked to BRS leaders K. Chandrasekhar Rao, K.T. Rama Rao, and T. Harish Rao. Commissioner of Collegiate and Technical Education A. Sridevasena has been appointed chairperson of the committee that has been tasked with examining violations of government rules in land listings.

‘There will be no shortage of prasadam at Sabarimala’

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

The Travancore Devaswom Board (TDB) has said that there will be no shortage of *aravana prasadam* during the Thulam month puja at Sabarimala and that adequate buffer stocks will be maintained ahead of the annual Mandalam-Makara-vilakku pilgrimage season. Addressing a press meet on Thursday, TDB president K. Jayakumar said the expansion of the *aravana* production plant was in its final stages and ruled out shortages in the future. The expansion would increase the plant's daily production capacity from 2.6 lakh tins to 3.6 lakh tins.

Dismissing reports that the Sabarimala gold crown had gone missing, Mr. Jayakumar said the 55-sovereign crown, donated by a devotee in 2012, was safely stored in the Sannidhanam strong room. The Thiruvabharanam Commissioner had personally verified its presence, he said. He also clarified that the confusion arose after a similar item was moved to the strong room at Aranmula. Mr. Jayakumar said the board had invited tenders three times to procure jagery for *aravana* production as part of efforts to ensure transparency in raw material procurement. A sample supplied by a Pune-based company had passed inspection, and the Devaswom Vigilance Superintendent of Police (SP) would visit the company to assess its capabilities. A ‘tender-cum-e-auction’ system would also be introduced for allocating shops at Sabarimala to curb irregularities in the auction process.

5 killed in coastal districts of A.P. as deep depression and heavy rain wreak havoc

Harish Gilai
VISAKHAPATNAM

The deep depression over the Bay of Bengal, which crossed the north Andhra Pradesh coast close to Kalingapatnam during the intervening night of Wednesday and Thursday, has wreaked havoc across Uttaraandhra, with five persons reportedly dying of electrocution in Anakapalli, Bapatla and Krishna districts. More than 50 trees were uprooted, electric poles were knocked down, multiple landslips occurred, road connectivity was cut off to many villages, and several colonies were inundated under the impact of heavy rain and gales. The system brought widespread rain to Uttaraandhra and parts of coastal and central Andhra Pradesh. The India Meteorological Department (IMD)

DYFI targets Keralam CM over chartered flight to Malappuram

G. Anand
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

A ‘freebie’ row centred on Chief Minister V.D. Satheesan's recent travel to flood-hit Malappuram district on a chartered flight lent by an “anonymous benefactor” appeared to dominate the political narrative in Keralam on Thursday. The Democratic Youth Federation of India (DYFI) is organising painting competitions across the State, urging the public to use their “imagination” to conjure up the likeness of the “mysterious sponsor” whose identity Mr. Satheesan had refused to reveal. In a cynical jibe at the

T.N. claims Cauvery shortfall, Karnataka points to ‘drought’

Tamil Nadu says it is suffering from a deficit of 20,000 tmc ft of river water while Karnataka says it did its best to comply with water disbursement responsibilities; T.N. claims kharif crop affected

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Thursday sought Karnataka's response to a plea by Tamil Nadu that it is suffering from a shortfall of 20 thousand million cubic feet of Cauvery river water.

Karnataka, in turn, submitted in the top court that it was facing a “terrible drought situation” and has complied, to the best, its responsibilities towards Tamil Nadu as an upper riparian State.

Appearing before a Bench headed by Justice Vikram Nath, both State governments concurred on the point that the Cauvery water was a “very sensitive” issue for them.



Both State governments concurred that Cauvery water was a ‘very sensitive’ issue. FILE PHOTO

“Karnataka is usurping all the water, depriving us of our own,” senior advocate C.S. Vaidyanathan submitted for Tamil Nadu.

Senior advocate Shyam Divan, for Karnataka, said entire districts in the State have been declared as

drought-prone. “Yet, we have taken it on the chin and done our best to comply,” he submitted.

The court gave Karnataka a week to file its response while scheduling the next hearing on October 12. Mr. Vaidyanathan, accompanied by senior ad-

Will appeal CWRC order: CM

CHITRADURGA The Cauvery Water Regulation Committee (CWRC) on Thursday recommended that Karnataka ensure a flow of 4,000 cusecs of water to Tamil Nadu for 15 days. “We will file an appeal...”, Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar said. PTI

SC rejects MLA’s plea over disqualification

The Hindu Bureau
HYDERABAD

The Supreme Court on Thursday declined to grant any relief to Danam Nagender, whom the Telangana High Court recently disqualified as Member of Legislative Assembly under the anti-defection law.

A Bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant, Justice Joymalya Bagchi and Justice V. Mohana, said the High Court's order did not re-

quire any interference.

Senior counsel Mukul Rohatgi, appearing for Mr. Nagender, contended that there was a provision in the Tenth Schedule to condone the action of a member for giving up the party membership. The court noted that provision was applicable only when a member voted against the party whip. It cannot be applied when a legislator gives up membership of a party, the Bench noted.

21-year-old’s ‘suicide’ revealed as murder

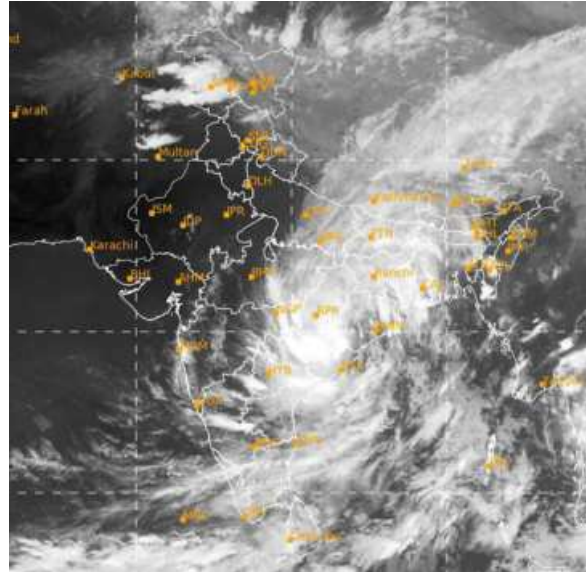
The Hindu Bureau
HYDERABAD

What initially appeared to be ‘death by suicide’ of a 21-year-old engineering student in Telangana turned out to be a murder after the Peddipalli police found that she had allegedly been forced to consume pesticide and that a note was part of an attempt to make her death appear self-inflicted. The police arrested Na-

veen Kumar, a lecturer at the Singareni Collieries Polytechnic, on charges of murdering Thandra Akshitarani and attempting to stage her death. Ravi Kumar, a Singareni overman accused of threatening, blackmailing, and intimidating her in the name of love, was also arrested. Both were taken into custody on September 20. (For those in distress, counselling is available at TeleMANAS 14416.)

WEATHERWATCH

Rainfall, temperature & air quality in select metros yesterday



Forecast for Friday: Heavy/very heavy rainfall likely at isolated places over Uttarakhand, Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, Assam, Meghalaya, Sikkim, West Bengal, Jharkhand, Odisha, Telangana, Andhra Pradesh, Chhattisgarh, Madhya Pradesh, Vidarbha, Kerala and Mahe

CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN	CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN
Agartala	1.1	33.5	23.9	Kurnool	15	30.5	23.4
Ahmedabad	36.3	27.7	1.8	Lucknow	29.6	25.0	2.0
Aizawl	21.8	31.9	20.0	Madurai	38.0	26.5	2.0
Bengaluru	27.9	20.0	29.0	Mangaluru	32.2	27.4	2.0
Bhopal	31.1	22.6	30.4	Mysuru	25.7	24.3	2.0
Bhubaneswar	59.7	28.0	26.2	New Delhi	18.1	25.7	24.3
Chandigarh	35.1	25.0	30.4	Patna	4.3	30.0	24.6
Chennai	36.3	27.9	0.4	Prayagraj	34.2	25.8	2.0
Coimbatore	33.4	23.9	36.4	Puducherry	27.2	22.8	2.0
Dehradun	32.3	21.8	32.6	Raipur	16	28.4	24.4
Gangtok	30.7	16.5	15.9	Ranchi	52	24	21.0
Goa	10	30.8	24.8	Shillong	2	23.6	17.4
Guwahati	0.2	34.5	25.9	Srinagar	27.7	11.5	2.0
Hubballi	27.0	22.0	32.1	Thiruvananthapuram	8	32.1	24.7
Hyderabad	7	28.2	23.7	Tiruchirappalli	36.9	26.6	2.0
Imphal	30.2	18.7	25.9	Vijayawada	144	26.6	24.0
Jaipur	34.6	25.8	27.7	Visakhapatnam	278	26.6	25.0
Kochi	5.2	31.0	25.2				
Kohima	27.0	17.0	32.1				
Kolkata	29	31.0	25.3				
Kozhikode	0.2	35.0	25.6				

Pollutants in the air you are breathing							Yesterday
CITIES	SO ₂	NO _x	CO	PM _{2.5}	PM ₁₀	CODE	In observation made at 4:00 p.m., Sri Ganganagar, Rajasthan recorded an overall air quality index (AQI) score of 315 indicating an unhealthy level of pollution. In contrast, Aizawl, Mizoram recorded a healthy AQI score of 14
Ahmedabad	26	49	36	117	126	126	
Bengaluru	21	22	21	28	53	53	
Chennai	8	10	26	38	113	113	
Delhi	10	57	53	166	206	206	
Hyderabad	10	13	34	51	62	62	
Kolkata	5	29	32	27	25	25	
Lucknow	7	21	40	41	56	56	
Mumbai	29	9	25	60	67	67	
Pune	9	31	93	68	118	118	
Visakhapatnam	9	30	24	12	19	19	

Air Quality Code: Poor Moderate Good (Readings indicate average AQI)
SO₂: Sulphur Dioxide. Short-term exposure can harm the respiratory system, making breathing difficult. It can affect visibility by reacting with other air particles to form haze and stain culturally important objects such as statues and monuments.
NO_x: Nitrogen Dioxide. Aggravates respiratory illness, causes haze to form by reacting with other air particles, causes acid rain, pollutes coastal waters.
CO: Carbon monoxide. High concentration in air reduces oxygen supply to critical organs like the heart and brain. At very high levels, it can cause dizziness, confusion, unconsciousness and even death.
PM_{2.5} & PM₁₀: Particulate matter pollution can cause irritation of the eyes, nose and throat, coughing, chest tightness and shortness of breath, reduced lung function, irregular heartbeat, asthma attacks, heart attacks and premature death in people with heart or lung disease

Karnataka creates 1.56 cr. person-days of job

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

Karnataka has generated 1.56 crore person-days of employment under the Viksit Bharat - Guarantee

for Rozgar and Ajeevika Mission (Gramin) (VB-G RAM G) scheme, as the State faces a severe drought situation, Rural Development and Panchayat Raj Minister Eshwar

Khandre told the Legislative Assembly on Thursday. In a response during a special discussion on drought, BJP member V. Sunil Kumar raised con-

cerns over the implementation of the employment scheme and said that preparations should have been made to utilise it on a larger scale in drought-affected areas.

EDUCATION HUB

A Business Initiative

SRMIST Welcomes Students



SRM Institute of Science and Technology (SRMIST) welcomed 250 MBBS and 100 BDS students at Freshers 2026, at the Dr. T. P. Ganesan Auditorium, Kattankulathur. Prof. V. B. Narayana Murthy, Plastic and Reconstructive Surgeon, Kauvery Hospital, Alwarpet, Chennai, as the Chief Guest, Prof. C. Muthamizhchelvan, Vice Chancellor, SRMIST, Dr. T. Mythili, Additional Registrar, MSL, SRMIST, Prof. (Dr.) Jayanthi R, Dean, SRM Medical College Hospital & Research Centre, Prof. (Dr.) Jayanthi R, Dean, SRM Medical College and Hospital, Dr. N. Vivek, Dean, SRM Kattankulathur Dental College and Hospital were present.

GSBM Inaugurates MBA Cohort



The Ganesan School of Business Management (GSBM) formally inaugurated its first Two Year MBA Programme, at its Chennai campus. Dr. A. S. Ganesan, Chief Patron, GSBM. “We have no interest in chasing scale for its own sake. Our ambition is to build Brand GSBM, known for the quality of what it delivers. “The transition to GSBM is much more than a change of name or identity,” said Prof. P. S. Balaganapathy, Director, GSBM. “The workplace our students will enter is changing faster than ever, particularly with technology and AI reshaping businesses and careers,” said Mr. Praveen Panikkassery, Director, Deloitte. Mr. Sundaresan Vennimalai, VP, Chief Data Office, Standard Chartered Bank; Ms. Shobha Venugopal, Head, Consumer Insights & Analytics, CavinKare; and Mr. Raman Pushkar, Founder, RP Consulting, with Mr. Praveen Panikkassery, Director, Deloitte were present.

S.A. College’s Graduation Day



S.A. College of Arts & Science celebrated its Graduation Day on the college campus. The ceremony was graced by the Board of Trustees, Chairman D. Duraiswamy, Principal Dr. S. Anbalagan, Secretary, D. Dhasarathan, Correspondent of SACAS & Sudharshan Vidhyashram Thiru. P. Venkatesh Raja along with directors and others. The Chief Guest Rajendra Vishwanath Arlekar, Governor of TN and Kerala, awarded degree certificates to a total of 1,065 graduates while 11 university rank holders and 22 academic toppers were honoured.

Sri Sairam’s Graduation Day



Sri Sairam Engineering College, West Tambaram, celebrated its 27th Graduation Day at the Sri Leo Muthu Indoor Stadium. Mrs. Kalaiselvi Leo Muthu, Vice Chairperson, Sairam Institutions, and Mrs. Revathi Sai Prakash, Director, Dr. J. Raja, Principal, Dr. Sai Prakash Leo Muthu, Chairman and CEO, Sairam Institutions, presided over the ceremony. Mr. J.C.D. Prabhakar, Speaker of the TN Legislative Assembly, attended as the Chief Guest and conferred a total of 1,451 students with degrees, including 1,249 UG, 202 PG students and 35 students secured Anna University ranks.

17th Edition of SEC’s DRESTEIN



Saveetha Engineering College (Autonomous) successfully concluded the seventeenth edition of DRESTEIN, its national-level technical and management fest. Over three days, the campus hosted an intensive programme of competitions, hackathons, workshops and industry interactions. DRESTEIN — an acronym drawn from DReam, dESign, compeTe and wIN — drew more than 9,500 participants from institutions across the country. The 2026 edition comprised 113 events and 38 hands-on workshops, with prize money worth Rs. 1 crore at stake across its flagship competitions. The fest was inaugurated on 10 September 2026 in the presence of Dr. N. M. Veeraiyan, Founder President and Chancellor, SIMATS, with chief guests- Mr. Sudeep Thomas Oommen, Innovation Director, Sopra Steria, and Mr. Navaneethakrishnan Balachandran, AI/Automation Delivery Manager, Tata Consultancy Services.

RIT Hosts Initiation Day

Rajalakshmi Institute of Technology (RIT), Chennai recently hosted its Initiation Day 2026. The event was graced by Mr. Sidd R. Siddharthan, Managing Director & Portfolio Lead, Life Sciences Accenture, as the Chief Guest, and Mr. Dhushyanthkumar T R, Director – HR, Renault Group, Renault Nissan Automotive India Pvt. Ltd., as the Guest of Honour. Dr. (Mrs.) Thangam Meganathan, Chairperson Rajalakshmi Group presided over the event, emphasising the importance of knowledge, character and ethical values. Mr. Sidd R. Siddharthan urged them to continuously adapt, while Mr. Dhushyanthkumar T R highlighted ideas, innovation and pursuit of excellence for students. The occasion was also graced by Dr. Haree Shankar Meganathan, M.D., Vice Chairman, Rajalakshmi Group.



A nation’s song

Vande Mataram’s rendition must be in the spirit of unity in diversity

Patriotism is not just reverence for a territory or a flag but is the embodiment of solidarity with fellow citizens in a nation-state. The idea of a nation as a bond transcends family, community or faith, uniting citizens through common values and a pursuit of prosperity. National symbols and anthems exist to hone that bond. When they are changed or modified to compel citizens to accept a majoritarian version, their purpose is defeated. India’s freedom fighting generation understood this. Which is why, in 1937, the Congress Working Committee resolved that only the first two stanzas of Bankim Chatterjee’s *Vande Mataram* should be sung at national gatherings, since the later stanzas invoke the motherland as Hindu deities. When *Jana Gana Mana* was adopted as the National Anthem on January 24, 1950, India’s first President Rajendra Prasad said that *Vande Mataram*, even though there is no mention of a “national song” in the Constitution, would be “honoured equally”. Since then, the two-stanza version has allowed citizens of all faiths to partake in a song that stirred the freedom struggle and popularised by artists such as Lata Mangeshkar and A.R. Rahman.

In the last year or so, the BJP-led Union government has sought to unsettle this inclusive compact. Since the song’s 150th anniversary in 2025, it has pushed for all six stanzas to be recited. The Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) issued directions and circulars in 2026 and Parliament passed the Prevention of Insults to National Honour (Amendment) Act, 2026 with little debate – actions that are in line with the BJP’s habit of imposing uniformity and majoritarian preference on all citizens. The amendment extends Section 3 of the 1971 Act, which punishes anyone who intentionally prevents the singing of the National Anthem or disturbs an assembly engaged in such singing, to the National Song. *Per se* it does not compel anyone to sing or define the National Song or its stanzas. But read alongside the MHA orders, which prescribe an official version of all six stanzas, mandate mass singing at public functions, and place the song before the anthem, it amounts to compulsion, as a petition by T.M. Krishna in the Supreme Court has argued. The Court has rightly observed that the state may decide what the National Song is, but cannot penalise conscientious objectors in line with *Bijoe Emmanuel* (1986). This judgment held that no law obliges anyone to sing the Anthem, standing in respectful silence is no offence and executive instructions without statutory backing cannot curtail fundamental rights. The Court must apply *Bijoe Emmanuel* in full, set aside the MHA’s orders and make it clear that silence cannot be read as “disturbance”. By reverting to the vision of the freedom generation, the Court will do justice to the idea of unity in diversity.

A chance to retreat

The Greenland agreement allows Donald Trump to scale down his threats

President Donald Trump first raised the possibility of acquiring Greenland, a Danish territory, during his first term in office. After his return to the White House in January 2025, he doubled down on his threat, saying that he would make the island American territory one way or the other. This incensed Denmark, a founding member of NATO, as well as America’s other allies in Europe. Denmark reassessed its sovereignty over the island but, as a compromise, promised to let the U.S. expand its military presence. On September 22, the leaders of the U.S., Denmark and Greenland signed a new security deal, which, according to Mr. Trump, would allow the U.S. to do “what is necessary in Greenland”. For Mr. Trump, who had even raised the possibility of using force to take over the territory, the deal is a retreat from his acquisition demand. But at the same time, it re-endorses the U.S. role as the primary security provider – it already stations some 150 troops in Greenland at its Pituffik Space Base. Under the agreement, Washington would build military facilities in Narsarsuaq in the south, where the U.S. had an airfield during the Second World War, and in Mestersvlg in the east, along the Norwegian Sea.

The 1951 U.S.-Denmark security agreement provides Washington the broad rights to build military bases in the ice-covered island. During the Second World War and the Cold War, the U.S. had more than 30 bases and installations on the island. Most were shut down over the years, particularly after the Cold War. In recent years, Trump administration officials raised concerns about the growing activities of China and Russia in the Arctic, including alleged espionage. As the Arctic region’s strategic profile is rising – partly because melting ice opens up previously impassable regions – the U.S. wants to consolidate its position and believes that Greenland would play a key role in that strategy. The agreement says that even if Greenland, which has a population of around 50,000, becomes independent, it would respect the deal with the U.S. and stay in NATO. In other words, this provides the U.S. indefinite access to the island’s military facilities. The deal also stipulates that no hostile power (non-NATO countries) can establish military facilities in Greenland or invest in its sensitive areas (mainly rare earths). Denmark has already blocked Chinese investments in the territory and the deal effectively formalises that restriction. So, on paper, Greenland could remain a self-governing, autonomous territory within the Kingdom of Denmark, while the U.S. would be its strategic patron with greater control – a diplomatic arrangement acceptable to Washington, NATO and Denmark.

One of the enduring ironies of the Indian political system is that political parties, which are considered the principal stakeholders of electoral democracy, do not find a mention in the Constitution, except in the Tenth Schedule. They exist as “associations” in furtherance of the fundamental rights under Article 19. No effort has been made to define and straitjacket their legal character to conform to being a company, trust, society, firm or a not-for-profit company. Even so, they continue to enjoy the benefit of income-tax exemption in an unprecedented and unparalleled manner, sometimes becoming mysterious receptacles of inexplicable monies. Just as there are shell companies that fulfil unstated purposes, there are shell political parties that serve an insidious intent. And thereby hangs a tale.

The mystery of political funding

That tale was partially unravelled by a recent BBC investigation that revealed extraordinary donations received by six Registered Unrecognised Political Parties (RUPPs). A well-known yet intriguing aspect of Indian politics – ugly and ubiquitous – stands exposed. Political parties and their benefactors thrive in this system, even if it appears reprehensible, unlawful and disturbing.

Earlier, the Association for Democratic Reforms (ADR) released a report on July 18, 2025, which found a 223% rise in the declared income of RUPPs in FY2022-23. It noted that, of the 2,764 RUPPs, only 739 had submitted their financial records for the year to the Election Commission of India (ECI), the sole custodian, under the law, of the fate and fortunes of political parties.

In a press note, “Cleaning up the Electoral System” (August 9, 2025), the ECI said it had ‘delisted’ 334 RUPPs out of 2,854 “as part of a comprehensive and continuous strategy...to clean up the electoral system.” It would be interesting to see whether the six parties in question are part of the ECI’s “continuous strategy”.

On October 16, 1994, T.N. Seshan, then Chief Election Commissioner of India, issued an order under the Election Symbols (Reservation and Allotment) Order, 1968, in which he highlighted the “adhocism” and the “sorry state of affairs prevailing in almost all political parties in the country, whether recognised National or State parties or registered-unrecognised parties”. He observed, “I have yet to come across any party whose affairs are being run in accordance with the provisions of its constitution or rules and regulations.” Through the order, T.N. Seshan put all political parties on “notice” to set their house in order, declaring that the ECI would not remain a “mute spectator”. In subsequent guidelines prescribing the format for registration under Section 29A of the Representation of the People Act (RPA), 1951, the ECI stated in paragraph 3(xxiii) that a party seeking registration must declare in its constitution that it will contest elections within five years of registration and that, if it does not “contest elections continuously



Ashok Lavasa

Former Election Commissioner of India and a former Union Finance Secretary

The Election Commission of India should scrutinise political parties and political finance rather than legitimate voters

for six years”, it shall “be automatically taken off the list of recognised parties”.

“Taking off” or ‘delisting’ does not mean deregistration, as the ECI is not generally empowered to deregister political parties. Similarly, even if RUPPs are ‘unrecognised’, they remain eligible to receive contributions under Section 29B of the RPA, while their tax treatment is governed by Section 13A of the Income-tax Act. “Recognition” is governed by Order 6 of the Election Symbols Order, which distinguishes between ‘recognized’ and ‘unrecognized’ political parties for the purpose of allotting symbols and lays down the criteria for their classification. T.N. Seshan amended the Symbols Order and introduced Order 16A, which empowers the ECI to “suspend or withdraw recognition of a recognised political party for its failure to observe MCC [Model Code of Conduct] or follow lawful directions and instructions of the Commission”. That provision sits, rather harmlessly, in the statute book, empowering an ECI that has generally been reluctant to strike.

Hence, whether ‘delisted’ or ‘unrecognized’, the parties remain eligible to receive contributions. It is a matter for investigation whether such donations continued to qualify for tax exemptions, given that the intent behind the delisting was to disqualify them.

The scale of ‘political wealth’

A paper published by Venkatesh Nayak, a senior researcher at the Commonwealth Human Rights Initiative (which was also reported by a leading media site), revealed that 22 political parties collectively had ₹18,742.31 crore at their disposal for the 2024 general election. This included funds in their kitty when the election was announced and ₹7,416.31 crore in donations raised between the announcement and the completion of the election. After the election, these parties had ₹14,848.46 crore remaining in their custody, including cash in hand, money held in bank accounts and fixed deposits, after incurring ₹3,861.57 crore in election-related expenditure during the campaign period, according to the accounts submitted to the ECI.

The study found that, over the last decade, the exchequer ‘lost’ ₹11,813 crore in taxes due to exemptions for political donations, with individual donors and Hindu Undivided Families overtaking corporates in donating to political parties. In FY2022-23, individual donors claimed exemptions worth ₹2,275.85 crore, dwarfing corporate claims of ₹514.4 crore and those of firms and associations, at ₹115.71 crore. Declared donations to political parties increased from ₹714 crore (43 parties) in 2015-16 to ₹7,203 crore (27 parties) in 2023-24. Yet, only 41.76% of total donations, amounting to ₹28,287 crore over nine years, were claimed as tax-exempt, raising questions about the remaining 58%. Mr. Nayak asks: “What incentives are driving them to donate without tax relief? The lack of transparency obscures answers.”

What added the thickest layer of secrecy was

the so-called reform of electoral bonds introduced by the ruling party in 2018, which made the entire business of political finance murky. Although the scheme was declared unconstitutional by the Supreme Court of India in 2024, the details of the donations subsequently disclosed raised questions that remain unanswered. Most RUPPs were not eligible to receive electoral bonds, as they were restricted to parties that had “secured at least 1% of the votes in the latest Lok Sabha or State Legislative Assembly elections”. Who, then, made these contributions, and why?

The top court and ECI must act

Political parties have shown scant interest in transparency. They united in resisting the 2013 order of the Central Information Commission (CIC) bringing them under the Right to Information Act. Interestingly, besides the CIC, neither the ECI nor the Supreme Court has shown any inclination to enforce it. The Income-Tax Department and the Enforcement Directorate might not consider it a priority to scrutinise the accounts of political parties as they do those of ordinary taxpayers. The ECI lacks the mandate, intent or wherewithal to question the accounts mechanically submitted by political parties. Submission of the accounts is enough to comply with the letter of the law, even if its spirit gasps. How will that spirit be revived, and who will revive it?

It is incumbent upon the Court to order a court-monitored probe into the saga of electoral bonds and the alleged *quid pro quo* in the petitions pending before it. The probe should also examine the phenomenon of ‘insignificant’ RUPPs receiving and spending huge contributions without participating in the electoral process in any substantial manner. Surely, such “shell” parties cannot justify spending crores as “administrative expenses”.

Exercising its powers under Article 324 – described by the Court in the landmark judgment of *Kanhiya Lal Omar vs R.K. Trivedi and Others* as a “reservoir of authority” for the ECI – the ECI should order political parties to have their accounts audited by the Comptroller and Auditor General of India or its nominee. It should also consider imposing a limit on expenditure by political parties during elections, a measure it has recommended repeatedly. Tax exemptions on donations should be limited to the prescribed expenditure limit. All other donations that enrich the parties should be fully taxed.

The ECI should establish an automatic procedure to ‘deregister’ any RUPP that does not contest elections in accordance with its guidelines and develop a centralised digital portal where all registered parties can upload their financial data in standardised formats.

Let the ECI spend its energy and authority on ‘purifying’ the electoral environment rather than on chasing genuine electors off the electoral rolls. Until then, ‘We the People’ must continue to scream *‘Hami yaha chhau* (we are here”).

Policing the line between publicity and justice

Within minutes of an arrest anywhere in India today, a face – handcuffed, flanked by policemen, sometimes garlanded with placards cataloguing the crime – starts circulating on social media, often before the accused is produced before a magistrate. A Supreme Court of India PIL seeking a nationwide media protocol/police media briefings has forced a question that Indian policing has quietly avoided: under what law do we do this, should we do it, and where should it stop?

Photographs of wanted persons and reward notices have solved crimes, helped recover missing children, and brought fugitives to book years after trails went cold – the public, alerted, has done what a thinly stretched police force alone could not.

The justification is strong; the legal architecture is weak. What is needed is a clear legal basis, not a habit inherited from mere precedent.

Current law and practice

No single statute permits or prohibits police from publishing photographs of accused persons. What exists is a patchwork of colonial-era regulations, an identification statute and the general architecture of criminal procedure.

Section 84 of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSS), 2023 (Section 82 of the Code of Criminal Procedure or CrPC) allows courts to proclaim absconders and publish proclamations in newspapers. It says nothing about photographs, but attaching one has become settled practice because it serves the purpose of securing the person’s appearance. This judicial process is triggered only after a warrant fails; it does not, however, provide a basis for publicity at the investigation stage.

Publication at the investigation stage rests instead on the general powers of an investigating



Rupin Sharma

IPS officer who is the Director General of Police, Nagaland

Before releasing the photograph of a person accused, arrested, but not yet tried, police must ask whether the investigation requires it

officer (Io): every person must assist the police in preventing and investigating offences, and an Io may examine anyone with relevant information. Publishing photographs on social media to solicit identification, trace absconders or find witnesses is a digital-age extension of the old “Hue and Cry Notice”, in State Police Manuals – provisions that predate Independence and whose language (“description of the subject”) is broad enough to plausibly cover photographs and rewards.

Reward announcements stand on firmer, narrower ground, typically governed by State Police Regulations under the Police Act, 1861, which vest sanctioning authority in a hierarchy ranging from the Station House Officer (SHO) to the State government. No prior warrant or proclamation is required; it is an exercise of administrative discretion, not a judicial precondition. The Criminal Procedure (Identification) Act, 2022, governs the taking, storage and use of measurements – including photographs – for identification, but is often wrongly cited as enabling their publication. It says nothing, however, about circulating them.

Constitutional limits

Article 21, jurisprudence has sharpened, not softened. Presumption of innocence remains central to criminal justice, and courts increasingly recognise that broadcasting an arrested person’s face as a fait accompli of guilt, before any charge is framed can cause real, irreversible harm. The Rajasthan High Court termed such practices “institutional humiliation” digital circulation is permanent, searchable and indifferent to later acquittal.

The Bureau of Police Research and Development prepared a draft manual on media briefings by police personnel and shared it with the Ministry of Home Affairs in July 2024. In January 2026, the Supreme Court said the *amicus*

had prepared a Police Manual for Media Briefing and directed the States to evolve appropriate policies based on it within three months. Some categories are already absolute red lines: a juvenile in conflict with the law cannot be identified except in the child’s best interest and with the Juvenile Justice Board’s permission; a sexual assault survivor’s identity is protected by law. The intriguing debate concerns the ordinary adult – accused, arrested, but not yet tried.

The distinction that matters

Publication sits on a scale: at one end, legitimate investigative necessity – crime prevention, public order and law-and-order purposes; at the other, the showcasing of police achievements. . Photographs released merely to showcase arrests serve police optics at the accused’s expense and can prejudice public opinion before trial.

American law treats “wanted” notices as public-record exceptions to privacy law, but agencies are trained to frame them carefully – “alleged,” “wanted for questioning” – to preserve the presumption of innocence even while seeking help. British policing, more conservatively, withholds arrested persons’ identities altogether.

What is needed is not an outright ban on soliciting public assistance – that would be legally unwarranted and self-defeating – but a codified, uniform national protocol that distinguishes proportionate, need-based disclosure from prejudicial publicity; mandates blackout categories such as juveniles and sexual-offence complainants; requires time-bound review and takedown once the investigative purpose is served or an accused is discharged or acquitted; and applies uniformly across States.

One question before any photograph goes out could be a beginning: is the disclosure necessary to the investigation, or merely convenient to the narrative?

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

State of the ECI

The Special Intensive Revision (SIR), one feels, is turning out to be a failed exercise in the country. Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar appears to have failed the Constitution and the people of the nation in the conduct of the

SIR. He should resign (Page 1, “Opposition calls for CEC’s exit over ‘illegal conduct’”, September 24). That said, why did Election Commissioners Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi remain silent for so long over their differences with the CEC on SIR deletions and related

issues, when the electoral damage has already been caused? There is something more to it than meets the eye. This is a constitutional crisis in the country. **S. Ramakrishnasayee**, Chennai

It is really astonishing to see the way things have been

unfolding at the Election Commission of India over the last few months. While everyone expects an autonomous constitutional body to function democratically, it appears to have become a one-man show under the leadership of Gyanesh Kumar. He has centralised

decision-making, lending credibility to the serious allegations made by the Opposition parties. **Kolikonda Sarathbabu**, Khammam, Telangana

It is extremely worrying to find the CEC in the eye of a storm. A position that shapes the destiny and fate

of the nation in the midst of a serious controversy does not augur well for the nation. Corrective action needs to be taken on a war footing.

Balasubramaniam Pavani, Secunderabad

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

Should permanent membership, veto powers of the UNSC be abolished?



Amitabh Mattoo
Dean of School of International Studies, JNU



Swaran Singh
Former Professor of the School of International Studies, JNU

PARLEY

In the ongoing session of the UN General Assembly (UNGA), France has made a proposal to enhance the functioning of the UN, especially in dealing with collective security and the use of veto. France has been advocating that the use of veto in the UN Security Council (UNSC) be “regulated” when it comes to dealing with humanitarian crises such as in Sudan, Lebanon or in cases of genocide. France believes that the use of veto is not a matter of “privilege” but of “responsibility”. So, should permanent membership and veto powers of the UN Security Council be abolished? Amitabh Mattoo and Swaran Singh discuss the question in a conversation moderated by Kallol Bhattacharjee. Edited excerpts:

Is it realistically possible to imagine an UNSC where veto would be “regulated” as the French proposal suggested?

Amitabh Mattoo: What Emmanuel Macron (President of France) articulated in the UNGA on September 22 is not entirely new. What we are seeing is really a renewed push behind what used to be called the French-Mexican initiative, first launched in 2015, under which permanent members of the SC would voluntarily refrain from using the veto in situations involving genocide, crimes against humanity, and large-scale war crimes. It’s not an attempt to abolish the veto or amend the UN charter. It’s essentially an exercise in self-restraint by the P5 (permanent members of the UNSC: U.S., U.K., France, China and Russia). What gives the initiative fresh significance is not just Mr. Macron’s speech, but the political momentum behind it. France and Mexico both announced this week that 128 states now support the declaration, with 21 joining in the last four months. And the significant part is that the U.K., another P5 country, has now joined France in accepting the principle.

So for the first time, two of the five permanent members have committed themselves to this form of voluntary restraint.

But I think we should also distinguish between three different questions which are often conflated – the use of the veto, accountability for the use of the veto, and the much larger question of reform of the Security Council. Mr. Macron’s initiative addresses only the first. It says in effect, even if the veto remains, surely there must be circumstances of exceptional human suffering in which a permanent member agrees not to exercise it. It is, as I said, a modest incremental proposition institutionally, but potentially significant



A general view of the UNGA in New York City, U.S., on September 22. REUTERS

normatively in terms of what we want the world to be like. It seeks to change the political behaviour of the five permanent countries without undertaking what seems to be the almost impossible task of rewriting the charter. So, it’s a modest proposal and it has got some momentum, but whether it translates into reality, we’ll have to wait and see.

Does the current situation in UNGA indicate that the P5 is now divided between the France-U.K. and Russia-U.S.-China factions on the use of veto?

Swaran Singh: Clearly, the U.K. and France are not the heavyweights among the P5. Therefore, I think it is easier for France and the U.K. to make that principled position saying that the P5, which wield veto power, should be able to better regulate or manage how fundamentally the power is utilised; to make sure that the UNSC is able to take action and that it does not get paralysed. In fact, the contradiction of 2013 itself was driven by the fact that in the civil war in Syria, Chinese and Russian vetoes were making it impossible for the UNSC to pass any resolution condemning Syria. After the August 2013 chemical weapons attack in Ghouta in September, the then French President Francois Hollande had in his speech proposed a ‘code of good conduct’ for the UNSC. This is where, for the first time, a kind of proposition was made that the P5 could voluntarily restrain the use of veto in cases of genocide, crimes against humanity or larger war crimes. I think the attempt was to skirt amending the UN Charter and still make it much more contemporaneous. None of the P5 are talking of eliminating veto power that they have. There are multiple versions among the five as to how they wish to reform the UN Security Council.

As an ideal, we believe that we live in a world



As an ideal, we believe that we live in a world of sovereign equality, but in reality, because of the way power is distributed, it is impossible for any international organisation to survive – not just become effective – but even survive if they happen to take a decision against any of the major powers

SWARAN SINGH

of sovereign equality, but in reality, because of the way power is distributed, it is impossible for any international organisation to survive – not just become effective – but even survive if they happen to take a decision against any of the major powers. Incidentally, veto is not a word mentioned in the UN Charter and it was created through a separate mechanism. But the premise is that any international organisation must not take a decision against the fundamental interests of any major power if they wish to survive.

While doubts persist about the veto, the question is will veto continue to be extended to new members of the UNSC whenever they are inducted?

AM: Apart from Mr. Macron’s or the France-Mexican initiative, there have been incremental reforms which fall short of trying to amend the UN Charter. There was an earlier Liechtenstein initiative, which was adopted by the UNGA in 2022, which took a different route. It did not prevent a permanent member from exercising the veto. Instead, whenever a veto was cast, the General Assembly would be convened within 10 working days to debate the issue. In other words, a veto will no longer be allowed to simply terminate the conversation. The permanent member concerned would have to explain and defend its action on the floor of the UNGA. That was one initiative which was passed by the UNGA. A third initiative, also similar to the French-Mexican initiative, is the ‘ACT code of conduct’ or the Accountability, Coherence and Transparency Initiative. This goes beyond the P5 and asks members of the Security Council, including the non-permanent members, not to vote against credible action designed to prevent or halt genocide, crimes against humanity and war crimes.

Again, its strength is moral and political rather than legally coercive. So I would resist the debate as being simply ‘retain or abolish the veto’. We now have several overlapping approaches – abolition, extension of the veto to new permanent members in the name of equality, voluntary restraint in case of

mass atrocities, political accountability after a veto is exercised, and the final question of broader structural reform of the Security Council itself. So my own analytical conclusion would be that Mr. Macron’s proposal matters precisely because it is pragmatic; reformist rather than revolutionary. Formal abolition of the veto would ultimately require charter amendment and the consent of the very permanent members whose privilege is being removed.

Can you please explain the issue of accountability in the debate on veto?

AM: Short of an amendment of the UN Security Council; an amendment of the veto provisions; or the larger restructuring of the UN Security Council, I think there is great merit in the ‘Liechtenstein initiative’, whereby the debate would continue within the UNGA. It would not prevent or terminate the conversation from happening in the floor of the UNGA, where the permanent member which has exercised the veto would have to clearly demonstrate to the members of the UN what the reasons were behind the exercise of the veto, especially when it has vetoed an action designed to prevent or halt genocide or crimes against humanity.

Calling upon the permanent member to explain and defend its actions would not necessarily prevent anything when there is real national self-interest at stake, but at least it will make the permanent members, one of the P5 countries which has exercised the veto, become a little more cautious in the use of its power because it would know that it would need to justify and become accountable for its action.

Is the French proposal transparent or honest about the framing of certain conflicts that are going on such as the Israeli campaign in the Gaza Strip?

SS: I think words such as honesty and justice are most misused in international relations. There is no doubt that all the UN members, whether they are in the Security Council or in the General Assembly, come to the world’s largest platform with their own interpretations, with their own understanding of each of these conflicts that you just listed. So in that sense, there is this important difficulty of word versus the spirit of various international law regimes or the Charter of the United Nations.



To listen to the full interview
Scan the code or go to the link
www.thehindu.com

NOTEBOOK

How rare archival photos revealed the magic of Madras

‘Madras on Stage’, the fourth edition of The Hindu’s ‘Made of Chennai’ archives exhibition showcased the rich cultural heritage of the city

K. Arunkumar

“Madras on Stage,” the fourth edition of *The Hindu’s* ‘Made of Chennai’ photo archives exhibition – held at Kasturi Buildings, the newspaper’s corporate head office – concluded on September 15. This year’s exhibition attracted a larger crowd than previous years, and notables from various walks of life visited it.

We at the Library Department, which serves as the archives of *The Hindu*, started collecting photographs for the exhibition in the second week of July. The curator, Thirupurasundari Sevel, suggested a division of 33% performing arts (national and international), 33% drama/stage, and 33% cinema. We chose to display pictures from the 1920s all the way to the 2010s to ensure that we did not miss out on any cultural activities or performing arts. We have in our repository nearly 2.5 to 3 million pictures across varied subjects, which include digital copies, black-and-white and colour prints, negatives, and colour transparencies. Of these physical prints, negatives, and transparencies, 60% were readily available in digital format; for the rest, we had to search through physical copies.

The curator gave us helpful clues and ideas. She also shared a timeline of key programmes and cultural events in Madras over the years. Using these leads, we cross-checked news items published in *The Hindu* and *Sport & Pastime* (a magazine published by The Hindu Group from 1947 to 1968), confirmed the dates, and searched our archives for pictures.

Finding some photos was tough, such as the 1927 photograph of Pammal Sambanda Mudaliar with the cast of his play by the Suguna Vilasa Sabha. Tracking down cinema stills of M.K. Thyagaraja Bhagavathar (MKT) shot in Madras was similarly exhausting. We hold only very few photographs from MKT’s films; the 1934 musical *Pavalakkodi*, directed by K. Subrahmanyam, provided the sole Madras-based still in our collection.

On the brighter side, we came across photographs of many international performers who appeared in Madras from the 1950s to the 1990s, including Boney. M, American jazz musicians, Egyptian folk dancers, Tibetan Amdo drama troupes, Russian Ramayana casts, and Russian ballet dancers. We collected a total of 600 pictures and shortlisted 181. Out of these, 100 pictures were physically exhibited, while all 181 were displayed on a television screen at the venue.

Right from the inauguration on August 14, school and college students visited the exhibition almost daily. Film and drama personalities, politicians, journalists, and public officials were among the other notable visitors. The exhibition was inaugurated by Tamil Nadu Minister for School Education, Tamil Development and Information A. Rajmohan. Tamil Nadu Minister for Hindu Religious and Charitable Endowments S. Ramesh also toured the display.

Historian and heritage activist V. Sriram appreciated the exhibits and helped identify several figures in the photographs – updates we have since incorporated into our archival captions.

Actor Pasupathy, whose photo from his Koothu-p-Pattarai days was on display, visited with his family and spotted a familiar face in the frame – retired Justice Prabha Sridevan, his co-star in *The Conduct of Life*, a play by Maria Irene Fornes. Actress and activist Revathi also dropped by, thrilled to spot three photographs capturing her participation in various social causes.

Other notable visitors included drama veterans Kathadi S. Ramamurthy, S.Ve. Shekher, and Madhu Balaji; theatre and television artist S. Varadarajan; cartoonist Madhan; singer Chinmayi; actor-journalist Chitra Lakshmanan; filmmaker Halitha Shameem; screenplay-dialogue writer Anand Kumaresan; and cinema PROs Diamond Babu and Nikhil Murukan.

We’re already looking forward to celebrating Madras again next year.

arunkumar.k@thehindu.co.in

PICTURE OF THE WEEK

Panorama of colour



Lightning strikes seen over the city skyline in Mumbai, Maharashtra on September 21. Several regions in the State have been facing a prolonged dry spell, causing extensive crop loss. The situation is so dire that the Maharashtra Cooperation Minister Babasaheb Patil said the government will soon declare 100% drought in the State. EMMANUAL YOGINI

FROM THE ARCHIVES

FIFTY YEARS AGO SEPTEMBER 25, 1976

No winner at Ford-Carter first round

Washington, September 24: The first face-to-face encounter between President Ford and his Democratic challenger, Mr. Jimmy Carter, last night lived up to the expectations of those who had organised this nationally televised 90-minute political spectacular – an opportunity for the American people to learn first hand from the two Presidential candidates, with their divergent economic philosophies, what they

The Hindu

proposed to do about such things like unemployment, inflation and taxes.

The confrontation over fiscal policies produced some sharp exchanges, though some of the dry statistics that were bandied about may have gone over the heads of ordinary viewers.

The debate was staged at Philadelphia’s Walnut theatre. The first of three bouts of the political prize-fight of the decade – the last such debate took place in 1960 when Kennedy and Nixon were contesting the Presidency – was marked by well-controlled exchanges by the Presidential rivals. Evidently, the two men had not only spent hours cramming facts and figures but also rehearsing to be seen as natural as possible before their audience.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO SEPTEMBER 25, 1926

Advertising the empire

An “Englishman” cable from London dated September 22 states: Emphasising that the opening of the Imperial Conference is expected to synchronise with the launching of the Empire Marketing Board’s £1,000,000 scheme for “advertising the empire”, “The Daily News” political correspondent suggests that this effort to focus the serious attention of British subjects to the Dominions might be strengthened partially by opening the Conference to the press. The paper says there is reason to believe that the British Government is not opposed to this.

M CH-CHE

CJP seeks resignation of CEC, warns of agitation

Gyanesh Kumar must resign in 48 hours to ensure free and fair elections, says Dipke; CJP also demands criminal proceedings against CEC and repeal of Act on appointment of poll body chief

Suruchi Kumari
NEW DELHI

The Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) on Thursday demanded the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar for “undermining” voter rights through the ongoing Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls.

The group warned of a nationwide agitation and a “Jantar Mantar 2.0” if Mr. Kumar did not step down within 48 hours.

The CJP’s demand for Mr. Kumar’s resignation comes a day after an investigation by *The Indian Express* revealed that the other two Election Commissioners, Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi, objected on record at least 14 times between October 2025 and August 2026 to decisions related to SIR, many of which, they said, were taken without their knowledge.



Seeking action: CJP leaders Saurav Das, Abhijit Dipke and Ashutosh Ranka speaking to the media. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

“To ensure free and fair elections, Mr. Kumar must resign,” CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke told a press conference. He alleged that the electoral process had been ‘rigged’ and that the right to vote was being taken away from citizens, for which the CEC was responsible.

Mr. Dipke said that Opposition parties should take a stand against election rigging. “If you know the election is rigged, you

should take a stand; you cannot both participate in the election and speak against rigging,” he said.

CJP co-convenor Saurav Das said, “Everywhere we are going as part of our *School Theek Karo* campaign, people are upset and asking for a change. One of the important tools for change is our right to vote. It cannot be compromised.”

Besides the call for the resignation, the CJP also

made two other demands, including criminal proceedings against the CEC.

CJP co-convenor Ashutosh Ranka said, “An independent inquiry commission should be constituted to look into all proceedings of SIR so far. The Supreme Court should seize all files related to decision-making in SIR before they are destroyed by EC.” He demanded that all the upcoming elections be halted and pre-SIR rolls of January 2025 restored in all States.

The CJP sought the repeal of the Appointment of Chief Election Commissioner and Other Election Commissioners Act 2023. “The new law should be redrawn with active participation of civil society, an independent selection process that inspires public confidence,” he said.

“We need to hit the streets. Who is Mr. Kumar to revoke our voting rights and strike our names off?” he added.

Opposition to move fresh notice in Parliament for Gyanesh Kumar’s removal

Sobhana K. Nair
NEW DELHI

The Opposition parties will move a fresh notice in both Houses of Parliament seeking the removal of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar, even as a previous petition moved in the Rajya Sabha on April 24 is pending with Upper House Chairman C.P. Radhakrishnan.

The Opposition is also gearing up for joint action on the issue and could soon call for a meeting under the banner of the Indian National Developmental, Inclusive Alliance (INDIA). A senior Opposition leader said that a dialogue is going on among like-minded parties to discuss the modalities.

In view of the Cockroach Janta Party’s 48-hour ultimatum calling for Mr. Kumar’s resignation, the INDIA bloc is anxious not to be seen as latecomers on the issue. “The Opposition will certainly be moving, especially in light of the



Gyanesh Kumar

new revelations. Our earlier motion submitted on April 24, in the RS had nine specific charges. That motion is still pending. There will be more specific charges,” Congress leader Jairam Ramesh said.

‘Must act swiftly’

The Trinamool Congress, which played a key role in the drafting of two previous petitions for Mr. Kumar’s removal, said a new petition should be moved at the earliest. “The Trinamool is very happy to play the role of a squirrel in the garden. The Opposition has to act unitedly and

swiftly,” party leader Derek O’Brien said.

It was on March 12 that the Opposition first moved a notice seeking Mr. Kumar’s removal. This notice was signed by 63 Rajya Sabha MPs and 130 Lok Sabha MPs. It contained seven charges against the CEC, including that his appointment itself was “tainted, with the law governing his selection, facing a challenge in the Supreme Court. The Opposition also claimed that Mr. Kumar’s previous postings reflected “deep executive embeddedness”. This notice was dismissed on April 7.

On April 24, the Opposition again moved a notice in the Rajya Sabha, signed by 73 Opposition members, this time with nine charges. The 13-page notice made several allegations including “mass disenfranchisement” in West Bengal and Uttar Pradesh, the “illegal abuse” of power and “asymmetrical enforcement of the Model Code of Conduct”.

Left parties to hold protests against SIR and CEC

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Five Left parties issued a joint statement demanding the ouster of Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar and a halt to the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls.

The parties announced a week-long protest across the country from September 26 to October 2 on the issue. The parties signed the statement after an impromptu meeting between Communist Party of India (Marxist) general secretary M.A. Baby, CPI general secretary D. Raja, and CPI (ML) Liberation general secretary Dipankar Bhattacharya at the CPI(M)’s headquarters. The other signatories are the Revolutionary Socialist Party, and the All India Forward Bloc.

The statement said the report confirms concerns repeatedly raised by Opposition parties and exposed the hollowness of claims that the SIR and electoral roll management process are transparent and decentralised.

SC advocate seeks to file contempt plea against CEC

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

Supreme Court advocate Brajesh Singh on Thursday sought statutory consent of the Attorney-General of India to initiate criminal contempt action against Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar following a media report revealing a “complete breakdown of multi-member consensus within the Election Commission (EC)”.

Referring to a report alleging “deep structural subversions”, he said that the other Election Commissioners, Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi, formally registered written objections at least 14 times over the last 10 months.

He submitted that the alleged actions by Mr. Kumar violated court precedents, which mandate that the EC must function through institutional consensus.

Mr. Singh said the CEC was only *primus inter pares* or first among equals. He did not possess absolute authority.

EC’s expanded logical discrepancy list keeps voters on their toes

Sreeparna Chakrabarty
NEW DELHI

Rajiv Chopra (name changed), a resident of Vaishali Colony in Pitampura in North West Delhi, was making last-minute preparations for a trip abroad when a neighbour called to inform him that his children were on the Election Commission’s logical discrepancy list that was being circulated in his society.

During a quick call to the booth-level officer (BLO), he learnt that his children had been flagged despite being in the draft list as the age gap between them was not more than

nine months. Well, it cannot be since his 30-year-old children are twins.

The mandatory nine-month age gap between siblings is one of the many categories of logical discrepancies that electors have to navigate to get into the voter lists during the third phase of the special intensive revision (SIR) exercise.

11 categories

Up to 11 distinct categories of logical discrepancies have been identified and applied across various States and Union Territories (such as Karnataka, Haryana, Delhi, Telangana and others), expanding from the original four cate-

gories initially used when the concept was introduced during West Bengal’s SIR exercise.

Among the categories are an age gap of less than 15 years between a voter and their parent; age gap of less than 40 years between a voter and their grandparent; more than six siblings linked with a single parent; discrepancies or spelling variations in a parent’s name between the current electoral roll and the previous revision; changes in relative mapping between revisions (e.g., father in previous rolls vs. mother in current rolls); marital mapping mismatch (e.g., fe-

Up to 11 distinct categories have been identified, expanding from the original four used in Bengal

male voter linked to her father in the previous roll but mapped to her husband in the current roll without cross-referencing; and age progression discrepancy (implausible age leaps or mathematical discrepancies between different revision cycles).

The discrepancies are flagged under a centralised AI system through the ERONet, or the Electoral Roll Officers’ Network. The

software attempts “progeny-mapping” – linking a voter to their parents’ entries on the base roll and the resultant inconsistencies are flagged.

The logical discrepancy category first surfaced during the SIR in West Bengal when approximately 1.36 crore voters received notices. In Delhi, where SIR is being done currently, 19.33 lakh electors have received discrepancy notices while 20.35 lakh have received the notices in Karnataka.

The problem in this is that “logical discrepancies” has never been clearly defined in any official communication – neither in the EC’s notice in May

2026 nor in the original SIR order from June 2025. Thus, the actual parameters or methodology used to assign someone to this category were not publicly documented.

Software issues

Another problem is with the ERONet software itself, which two Election Commissioners have flagged for having become increasingly centralised. They have said that Electoral Registration Officers (EROs) have complained that they are unable to access the platform from their end in many cases. Former Trinamool Congress MP and Right to Information Act

activist Saket Gokhale alleged that the EC was “hiding” details of the software, claiming it was a “trade secret”. In a post on X, he shared RTI applications in which he had asked the EC about details of the software. “Shocking-ly, the EC refused to disclose the details claiming it would affect ‘commercial confidence’”, he said.

“The software consists of an opaque algorithm which has been used to delete voters through a centralised system in Delhi [bypassing EROs]. A software used by a public authority is being kept secret for commercial interests,” he said.

PUDUCHERRY TECHNOLOGICAL UNIVERSITY
A STATE UNIVERSITY OF THE GOVT OF PUDUCHERRY
(ERSTWHILE PONDICHERY ENGINEERING COLLEGE)
PILLAI CHAVADY, PUDUCHERRY - 605014

Advt. No. PTU/REG/RECRUITMENT/2026/1087 Date: 21-09-2026

NOTIFICATION FOR THE RECRUITMENT OF REGISTRAR

Puducherry Technological University invites applications from eligible candidates for appointment to the post of Registrar.

The appointment is for a tenure of 3 years.

The details regarding the post, essential qualifications, emoluments, terms and conditions of service, application procedure, and other relevant information are available on the website <https://dhte.py.gov.in> & <https://ptuniv.edu.in>

Last Date for Submission of Online Application: 31/10/2026 (5.00 PM IST)

Last Date for Receipt of Hard Copy of Application with Endlosures: 07/11/2026 (5.00 PM IST)

No.212/DIPI/AD (PRESS)/2026-27 REGISTRAR (i/c)

BHUBANESWAR DEVELOPMENT AUTHORITY
AKASH SHOVA BUILDING, SACHIVALAYA MARG, BHUBANESWAR - 751001
PABX No. 0674-2392801 / 0998 / 6437, FAX No. 0674-2390633 / 085; Visit us at: <http://www.bda.gov.in/>

Invitation For Bids - Bid Identification No.528/EM/BDA/2026-27 Date: 22/09/2026

Engineer Member, BDA on behalf of Bhubaneswar Development Authority, Bhubaneswar invites percentage rate bids in double cover system in ONLINE MODE from eligible contractors for civil works as mentioned below:-

- Nature of works : Shaded Cycle Track & Footpath Pavement at Left parallel Road (Ekamra Kanan to Hatiasuni)
- Total No. of works : 01 (One) No.
- Amount put to tender : Rs.7.85 Crore
- Class of Contractor : "A" and "Special" Class
- Period of Completion : 6 (Six) Calendar months
- Cost of Bid Documents : Rs.10,000.00 + 18% GST=Rs.11,800.00
(Online transfer by the last date & time for receipt of bids)
- Earnest Money Deposit (EMD) : 1% of estimated cost put to tender
(Online transfer by the last date & time for receipt of bids)
- Availability of Tender : From 25.09.2026 to 5.30 PM of 09.10.2026
<https://tendersodisha.gov.in>
- Date of opening of Tender : Dt.12.10.2026 at 11.30 AM
- Place of opening of Tender : O/o - Engineer Member, BDA, Bhubaneswar.

Further details can be seen from the website: <https://tendersodisha.gov.in>. Any addendum / Corrigendum / cancellation of tender can also be seen in the said website.

CE-Res-EM, BDA, Bhubaneswar.
13001/1949/2627 OIPR-13001/13033/1/26-27/0143

Indian Overseas Bank
Information Technology Department
Central Office: 763, ANNA SALAI, CHENNAI-600002

Indian Overseas bank (IOB) invites bids for the following:

GOVERNMENT E-MARKET PORTAL - SELECTION OF NETWORK INTEGRATOR FOR THE BANK FOR A PERIOD OF (5) FIVE YEARS.

BID NO: GEM/2026/B/8024186 DATED 10.09.2026
Kindly note that the earlier tender floated vide bid ref no: GEM/2026/B/7905091 dated 11.08.2026 is cancelled

The Above GEM Tender document is also available and can be downloaded from the following websites www.iob.bank.in & www.gem.gov.in. For Tender details and future amendments, if any, keep referring to the following website www.gem.gov.in.

Indian Overseas Bank
Information Technology Department
Central Office: 763, ANNA SALAI, CHENNAI-600002

Indian Overseas bank (IOB) invites bids for the following:

GOVERNMENT E-MARKET PORTAL - SELECTION OF SERVICE PROVIDER FOR ATM SWITCH & DCMS UNDER OPEX MODEL FOR A PERIOD OF 5 YEARS.

BID NO: GEM/2026/B/8070903 DATED 22.09.2026

The Above GEM Tender document is also available and can be downloaded from the following websites www.iob.bank.in & www.gem.gov.in. For Tender details and future amendments, if any, keep referring to the following website www.gem.gov.in.

अधिशायी अभियन्ता, राजस्थान राज्य कृषि विपणन बोर्ड, खण्ड-जयपुर द्वितीय
क्रमांक :- अधि.अभि./जयपुर/भा.वि.बी./2026-27/राजकाज रफ नं. 24677265 दिनांक :- 24/09/2026

बिड आमंत्रण सूचना संख्या-09/2026-27

राज.रा.कृ.वि.बोर्ड खण्ड जयपुर प्रथम, जयपुर द्वितीय, दर्भिनस मार्केट जयपुर, दौरा, अलवर एवं टोंक के सिंचित निर्माण कार्य हेतु ऑनलाईन बिड ई-प्रोक्यूरमेंट के माध्यम से उपयुक्त श्रेणी में पंजीकृत बिडर्स से आमंत्रित की जाती है। बिड से संबंधित विस्तृत विवरण वेबसाइट www.eproc.rajasthan.gov.in, www.sppp.rajasthan.gov.in एवं www.agriculture.rajasthan.gov.in/rsamb पर भी देखा जा सकता है। (UBN No. AGM2627WSOB/LOB0026 to 52)

राज.संसाधन/सी/26/10676 अधिशायी अभियन्ता

GOVERNMENT OF PUDUCHERRY
SPECIAL BUILDINGS DIVISION-4, PUBLIC WORKS DEPARTMENT

e-TENDERING NOTICE INVITING BID THROUGH REP

On behalf of the President of India, Bids are invited for "Providing Engineering, Procurement and Construction (EPC) services on Turnkey Basis for the Construction, Erection and Commissioning of Effluent Treatment Plant of 250 KLD including the first 2 years forming part of defect liability period and the following 5 years as paid operation and maintenances at Indira Gandhi Government General Hospital and Post Graduate Institute (IGGGH & PGI), Puducherry" Bid Security: Rs. 8,02,000/- (Eight Lakhs & Six Thousand Only) (Including Monsoon period) with 2 years DLP & 5 years of O & M.

Last time & date of submission of tender: 04.00 P.M. on 13/10/2026
For further details please refer the website www.pudutenders.gov.in from 10.00 AM on 24/09/2026.

sd/-
NO: 210/DIPI/AD(Press)/2026-2027 EXECUTIVE ENGINEER

GRIDCO LIMITED
(A Govt. of Odisha Undertaking)
Regd. Office : Janpath, Bhubaneswar-751022, ODISHA

Notice for submission of EoI

Eol No: GRIDCO/ EoI/ 2026-27/ 01 Dated: 23.09.2026

GRIDCO Limited invites EoI from eligible inter-State power utilities, Distribution Licensees, State Designated/ Power Procurement Entities, other eligible entities and CERC-licensed inter-State electricity traders for purchase/offset of 50 MW Round-the-Clock (RTC) Non-RE power for a period of five (5) years commencing from 01.12.2026.

For necessary details visit: www.gridco.co.in
sd/- Director (T & BD)
4001/329/2627 OIPR-4001/4056/1/26-27/0021

MAHATRANSCO
Maharashtra Gas Electricity Transmission Co. Ltd.

INVITATION FOR BID (IFB) (LOCAL COMPETITIVE BIDDING)

SRM e-Tender No. T-2666/MSETCL/CO/Projects/Pre-Tender (RFx No. 6000001580) (6" Call)

MSETCL invites offers by SRM e-tendering in TWO bid system (Techno-Commercial Bid and Price Bid) from the eligible registered bidders for the following work as detailed below.

"Construction 400kV D/C line from LILO on 400kV Waluj Bhusawal line Circuit II to 400kV Thaptitanda Substation (Route Length-22.43km) under Ch. Sambhajinagar Zone, MSETCL, Maharashtra."

Interested bidders may obtain further information available on the website <https://srmetender.mahatransco.in>

The date of downloading of Bid documents available on the website is from 23.09.2026.

sd/-
Chief Engineer (Projects), MSETCL

GOVERNMENT OF INDIA
Public Enterprises Selection Board
invites applications for the post of
Director (Commercial)
in
Rashtriya Ispat Nigam Limited (RINL)

Last date of submission of online application by applicants is by 15:00 hours on
13th October, 2026

Last date of forwarding of applications by the Nodal Officers on online system of PESB is by
17:00 hours on
22nd October, 2026

For details login to website
<https://pesb.gov.in>

Link for registration of nodal officers/ competent authorities is available on PESB website.

GOVERNMENT OF TELANGANA
DEPARTMENT OF HORTICULTURE

INVITATION OF APPLICATIONS
ESTABLISHMENT OF OIL PALM FACTORIES IN TELANGANA
NOTIFICATION

Telangana is one of the biggest producers of Palm Oil in the Country. There is tremendous potential for Oil Palm development in Telangana. Government of Telangana has already allotted (14) companies to carry out oil palm area expansion operations across the State. In view of the cancellation of Narayanpet district factory zone, Government of Telangana has decided to invite applications for re-allotment of factory zone for Oil palm cultivation.

S.No.	District	Potential Area (hectares)
1	Narayanpet	5000

Under Oil palm (Regulation of Production and Processing) Act 1993, Government is empowered to allot factory zones in favour of Agencies selected for Oil Palm area expansion and setting up of Oil palm processing units. Interested Firms / Companies/ Co-operatives desirous of setting up of Oil Palm Processing unit may download the application form from the website <http://horticulture.tg.nic.in> from 25.09.2026. The filled-in application form to be submitted in the Oil palm Section, O/o, Director of Horticulture, Public Gardens, Hyderabad - 500004 on or before 08.10.2026, 5.00 PM by paying an amount of Rs.20,000/- (Non-refundable) towards application fee and Security deposit of Rs.1,00,000/- through separate DDs in favour of Secretary, SHN, Payable at Hyderabad. Applications may also be obtained from Oil palm Section, O/o, Director of Horticulture, Public Gardens, Hyderabad - 500004 on all working days from 25.09.2026 onwards, between 10.30 AM to 5.00 PM, by paying an amount of Rs.20,000/- (Non-refundable) through DD in favour of Secretary, SHN, Payable at Hyderabad. Last date for submission of completely filled in applications is 08.10.2026, 5.00 PM.

sd/-Director of Horticulture,
Telangana State
DIPR R.O.No.577-PP/CL-AGENCY/ADVT/2026-27 Dt:24-09-2026

Actor Mushtaq Khan, known for his character roles in over 500 films, including hits such as *Welcome*, *Gadar* and *Hum Hai Rahi Pyaar Ke*, has died after a battle with cancer, his son Mohsin said. He was 75. Khan was admitted to Nanavati Hospital in suburban Mumbai about a fortnight ago. "He passed away due to cancer at Nanavati Hospital at around 7 p.m. He had complained of stomach pain, so we took him to the hospital, where doctors discovered that he has cancer. His health worsened in the last few days," Mr. Mohsin said. He is survived by wife, son and a daughter. PTI

A Delhi court on Thursday permitted a U.S. national and six Ukrainian nationals, held by the National Investigative Agency (NIA) in a terror case, to travel to their respective countries for one month. Special Judge Prashant Sharma of the Rouse Avenue Court permitted U.S. national Matthew Aaron VanDyke to travel to his country while Hurba Petro, Slyviak Taras, Ivan Sukmanovskiy, Stefankiv Marian, Honcharuk Maksim alias Maksym, and Kaminskyi Viktor were allowed to travel to Ukraine. The accused had sought permission to leave India to meet their families, stating that they had not seen them for nearly 10 months.

The CBI on Thursday said it has arrested Abhishek Kumar, one of the purported kingpins in the alleged ₹6,000 crore Mahadev online betting app scam. Mr. Kumar was arrested at the Rajiv Gandhi International Airport in Hyderabad immediately after his flight from Dubai landed there on Thursday, said a CBI official. Abhishek Kumar is accused of running online betting and gambling operations under Mahadev Book, in coordinating the panels, in collection of funds and in acquiring immovable assets in Dubai out of the ill-gotten proceeds of betting and gambling, the official added. So far, the CBI has filed eight chargesheets against 100 accused persons in the case.

A tiger cub, rescued from a house in Assam's Biswanath district on September 17, has been released in the Kaziranga National Park and Tiger Reserve. The forelimbs of the cub, estimated to be three months old, were found entangled in a kitchen garden net behind the house in Natungaon village. Officials said the cub could have wandered into the village after getting separated from its mother because of strong river currents. A rescue team surveyed the neighbouring riverine islands to locate the mother. It subsequently shifted the cub to the Central Range Office of Kaziranga's Biswanath Division for veterinary observation.

Jagriti Chandra
NEW DELHI

Facial recognition-based airport access system Digi Yatra is preparing to extend its biometric travel system to international departures, while also pursuing interoperability with the European Union's equivalent framework that will allow travellers from India easy airport access overseas and expanding domestic access for foreign travellers.

The pilot programme for international departures will run between October and December at Bengaluru, Delhi, Hyderabad, Kochi and Mumbai airports, Digi Yatra CEO Suresh Khadakhavi told *The Hindu*.

Verifying with selfie

It will test electronic passport-based enrolment, allowing travellers to scan an e-passport and verify their identity with a selfie.

The resulting digital credential will be stored on the passenger's phone and linked to a boarding pass that airlines will issue before passengers arrive at the terminal.



A Digi Yatra gate at the departure block of Vijayawada International Airport, at Gannavaram, Andhra Pradesh. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Air India and IndiGo are expected to participate in the trial, which will cover Indian and foreign nationals departing on international flights. Initially, the system will be used at airport entry points and security checkpoints.

Immigration will remain outside the first phase because of its regulatory and operational sensitivity, Mr. Khadakhbavi explained.

The issuance of boarding pass before passengers arrive at the airport marks a departure from current practice. The Digi Yatra CEO said it is needed to create a unique digital



Through their APTI-TUDE consortium, the platform aims to enable cross-border sharing of travel credentials within three to six months. The longer-term objective is for a passenger travelling from India to Europe to share verified credentials with both departure and destination airports.



Block of Vijayawada International
des. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

The effort is part of a broader self-sovereign identity push under the global airline body International Air Transport Association's One ID initiative for contactless air travel.

identity that can be recognised at airport gates. The three-month trial will also collect passenger feedback before any wider rollout, including possible

Domestically, Digi Yatra is active at 39 airports and is expected to reach 64 by March 2027, according to the Ministry of Civil Aviation.

domestic use for expatriates and other foreign travellers. Face recognition is mandatory at terminal entrances and security check-

Working with EU

Alongside the airport trials, Digi Yatra is working on interoperability with

the European Union's digital identity framework, known as EU Digital Identity that allows EU citizens, residents, and businesses to store and share verified digital identity data and of-

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) has proposed a draft amendment to the Food Safety and Standards (Prohibition and Restrictions on Sales) Regulations, 2011, to restrict the manufacture and sale of analogue products as "Paaneer" and prevent consumers from being misled about the nature and composition of such products, noted a release issued by the Union Health Ministry on Thursday.

The proposed Food Safety and Standards Amendment Regulations, 2026 seek to insert a new clause under Regulation 2.1.1 of the existing regulations, specifically covering “paneer made of constituents not derived from milk”.

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Union government on Thursday reduced the Basic Customs Duty (BCD) on major imported crude edible oils, including palm oil. A statement from the Union Food and Consumer Affairs Ministry said the decision was taken to moderate domestic edible oil prices, provide relief to consumers, and mitigate “inflationary pressures” arising from the “sharp increase in international edible oil prices”.

The BCD on crude sunflower oil has been reduced from 10% to nil, while the BCD on crude soyabean oil and crude palm oil has been reduced from 10% to 5%. "The Government has simultaneously reduced the applicable BCD on the respective refined edible oils while



The government said it has maintained the duty differential between crude and refined edible oils. FILE PHOTO

maintaining an import duty differential of 19.25% between crude and refined edible oils. The duty rationalisation takes into account the increase in international edible oil prices and the consequent rise in domestic landed costs and retail prices," the Centre said, adding that import duties constitute an important component of the landed cost of imported edible oils, and therefore have a bearing on domestic market prices.

The Centre expects that the reduction in BCD on crude edible oils will lower their landed cost and facilitate transmission of the benefit through the domestic supply chain. "The measure is intended to provide relief to consumers," it said.

Duty differential

The government said it has maintained the duty differential between crude and refined edible oils to support the utilisation of dom-

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

The Assam Cabinet on Thursday approved a rule that makes registration of Muslim marriages compulsory in the State.

The Assam Muslim Marriage Registration (Compulsory) Rules, 2026, operationalise the registration framework under the Assam Compulsory Registration of Muslim Marriages and Divorces Act, 2024, which replaced a piece of legislation enacted in 1935.

The colonial-era law had provided for voluntary registration, although a 2010 amendment had made registration compulsory.

The 2024 legislation repealed the 1935 law arguing that the old framework was outdated and could allow registration of marriages involving minors.

SUDOKU



2	4	8		5	3		9
1		3				8	6
	1		3		6	9	
				7			
		2	5		1		3
	8	1				3	
							5
	3		9	2		7	1
							8

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★

Solution to previous puzzle

B	E	V	I	T	R	A	C	K	B	A	L	L	S
E	A	R	T	D	E	C	O	Y	I	E	O		
C	E	T	E	L	L	E	T		C	A	P	I	T
H	A	R	B	O	U	R	E	L	A	T	E	D	
H	A	U	A						N	R	E		
O	W	N	E	R		G	O	N	S	E	N	S	
				K	A							T	
S	A	R	G	A	S	S				E	N	V	O
E	H	L	E							R	A	M	
D	U	M	D			P	I	R	A	N	H	A	
H	B	E	O	L		O	G					T	
A	G	A	I	N	S	T		A	P	R	I	O	R
I	R	A	T			T	S						
P	U	R	E	D		P	E	E		S	H	U	N

Solution to yesterday's puzzle

3	9	2	5	8	4	7	6	1
4	1	5	7	6	9	2	8	3
6	7	8	3	2	1	9	4	5
5	4	6	9	7	8	1	3	2
7	2	3	1	4	6	5	9	8
1	8	9	2	5	3	4	7	6
8	6	7	4	1	5	3	2	9
2	3	1	6	9	7	8	5	4
9	5	4	8	3	2	6	1	7

We must have a thirst for knowledge. We must not see education as a mere tool to help us earn money. Education is much more than a mere enabler of wealth, said R. Narayanan in a discourse. Poet-philosopher Thiruvalluvar advises us about how we should seek knowledge. If a man needs financial help from someone, he asks humbly. We cannot adopt a demanding tone when we ask someone for a loan. In the same way, when we seek instruction from a knowledgeable person, we should do so humbly, says Thiruvalluvar.

In *Purananuru*, the king Ariya Padai Kadantha Nedunchezhian says we must help our teachers when they need help. If they are in need of money, we should give generously to them. A learned man commands more respect than a king. A ruler is respected only within his country. But an educated man is respected wherever he goes. Poet Avvaiyar stresses this in her *Moothurai*.

Poet Bharatidasan tells us how we should study. He says we should read and that we must particularly read Sangam literature. He says we must have a 24-hour engagement with learning. The grammar work *Nannul* says we should be on time for our lessons. Since a teacher is equal to God, we should respect a teacher just as we respect God. When it comes to learning, we must be like a hungry man who relishes food and like a thirsty man who enjoys a drink of cool water. *Nannul* says we must study everything thoroughly, so that we never make mistakes. We must not stop with this. We must discuss what has been taught with fellow students. The Jain work *Naladiyar* says education is a medicine for all problems.

INBRIEF



NSE India lists on BSE at a modest premium of 0.8%

National Stock Exchange of India Ltd. (NSE) made a modest debut on the Bombay Stock Exchange (BSE), with its shares opening at ₹1,800 apiece, a 0.8% premium over its initial public offering (IPO) price of ₹1,785. The exchange operator's over ₹22,200 crore IPO, one of India's largest market listings, came to fruition after a decade-long regulatory and legal overhang. The issue size was reduced before launch. After opening slightly higher, NSE shares gained further momentum during the session, rising about 1% from the opening level to close at ₹1,818 on the first day of trading. Speaking at the listing ceremony held on the BSE trading floor, NSE CEO Ashish Kumar Chauhan said capital markets are a signal of a well functioning society.

‘West Asia crisis not over, potential to escalate further’

The West Asia crisis is not over and has the potential to exacerbate, Oil Minister Hardeep Singh Puri said at the Public Affairs Forum of India's annual conclave on Thursday. He added that notwithstanding the prevailing situation, a potential silver lining is the abundant availability of crude oil in the global market. “The crisis is certainly not over; it is not only ongoing, but it has the potential of exacerbating. In other words, it could get more serious,” he said. Highlighting that global crude availability remains higher than current demand; he said around 102 million barrels per day (mb/d) of crude oil is available in the market, while India's domestic requirement is estimated at 94-95 mb/d. Mr. Puri also ruled out restricting exports amidst tightened market conditions. A return of stability could help keep crude prices under control, he said. “I am hoping with all the counsels of peace around the world, peace will come and the price of oil should be lower rather than higher,” Mr. Puri said.

‘Make in India’ of 12 years shows patchy performance

Analysis of metrics shows manufacturing sector has not been able to materially increase its share in economic growth, employment, or global exports; incentive gains confined to some sectors

TCA Sharad Raghavan
NEW DELHI

Twelve years on from the launch of the Make in India campaign on September 25, 2014, a look at 12 metrics spanning growth, investment, employment, and exports shows India's manufacturing sector has not been able to materially increase its share in India's economic growth, employment, or global exports.

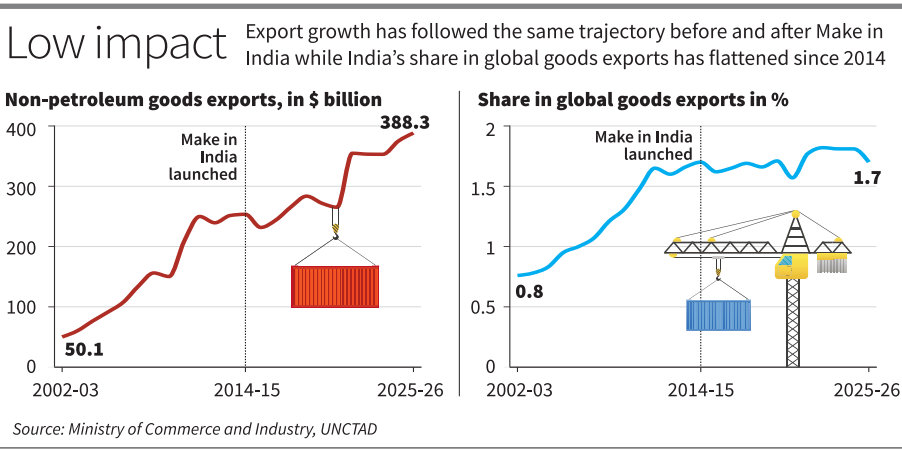
While recent incentive schemes by the government have seen some success, those gains are limited to a handful of sectors.

The manufacturing sector has grown faster than the overall economy in only half of the 12 years under consideration, based on the old series. Under the new series, it has outpaced overall growth in all three years (2023-24 to 2025-26) for which data is available, but that gap is shrinking fast. The Index of Industrial Production (IIP) data, which comes out once a month, is more stark.

The manufacturing sector within the IIP outpaced the overall index's growth in only three out of the 12 years, as per the old series of the index.

The new series shows the manufacturing sector's growth was the same as that of the overall index in 2023-24, but was slower in the next two years.

As far as the composition of the economy goes, the older series of Gross



Value Added (GVA) data shows the manufacturing sector's share in overall GVA is lower in 2025-26 than it was when Make in India was launched in 2014. The new series shows that the sector's share has increased marginally from 14.6% in 2022-23 to 15.6% in 2025-26.

India saw the value of its non-petroleum goods exports grow 53% to \$388.3 billion in 2025-26 from \$253.5 billion the year the Make in India campaign was launched.

However, the data also shows that non-petroleum goods exports grew more than 400% over the 12 years before this, albeit on a much smaller base.

However, the base effect only accounts for some of this growth disparity. Data from UNCTAD shows India's share in global merchandise exports grew from around 0.8% in 2002 to 1.7% in 2013, where it remained even in 2025-26.

The gross fixed capital

formation (GFCF) by the private sector – a measure of its spending on real asset creation – formed a lower share of GDP in 2023-24, the latest year for which the old series has data, than it did in 2014-15. The new series, too, shows that GFCF as a percentage of GDP has been falling since 2022-23.

The growth of foreign direct investment (FDI) to the manufacturing sector has been slower than the growth in overall FDI in 7 of the 12 years under consideration. Its share in overall FDI grew from nearly 48% in 2014-15 to 55% in 2025-26. The RBI's data on capacity utilisation, a measure of how intensively factories are being used, shows this metric has been slowly increasing over the last few years, but is still below the 80% mark that is considered the limit after which companies invest to create new capacity.

The RBI's data further shows that bank credit to

industry has been growing strong over the last few years, especially led by credit to micro, small, and medium enterprises. However, experts have pointed out that, in the absence of sustained rapid growth in output, this suggests that the loans are being taken to provide working capital rather than for fresh investments.

The government's Production-Linked Incentive schemes have yielded some results. Launched across 2020 and 2021, the 14 schemes have resulted in a cumulative investment of ₹2.4 lakh crore as of March 2026. However, the data also shows that this performance is highly concentrated. The top five sectors – solar modules, pharmaceuticals, drugs, automobiles and their components, specialty steel, and large scale electronics manufacturing – together account for nearly 83% of all the investment under these schemes.

Crude price surge, insurance reforms trigger market slide

Ashokamithran T.
MUMBAI

Indian benchmark equity indices fell sharply on Thursday, declining 1.7% as a spike in global crude oil prices, weak international cues and concerns over proposed insurance sector reforms weighed on investor sentiment.

The Nifty 50 slipped 1.7% to 23,064 points, while the Sensex dropped 1.7% to 73,580 points compared with the previous close. The decline reflected broader risk aversion among investors amid renewed uncertainty over global geopolitical developments and rising bond yields.

Oil prices emerged as a key concern for markets, with Brent crude futures rising for the second consecutive session to \$104.86 a barrel, gaining more than 5% since September 22. The sharp increase in crude prices raised concerns over inflationary pressures, corporate margins and India's import bill, given the country's dependence on overseas energy supplies.

Domestic equities also faced additional pressure from the insurance sector after the Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India (IRDAI), in its consultation paper 'Recalibrating Economics of Insurance Distribution', proposed changes, covering distribution structures, expenses, commissions, market conduct and transparency norms, triggered



Sensex dropped 1.7% to 73,580 points compared with the previous close. REUTERS

heavy selling in insurance-related stocks and intermediaries.

“PB Fintech (down 36%), TurtleMint (down 20%) and MFSL (down 10%) came under heavy selling pressure following IRDAI's consultation paper, which proposed sweeping changes to distribution structures, expenses, commissions, market conduct and transparency,” said Nandish Shah, Deputy Vice-President, HDFC Securities.

Elevated volatility

Market participants said the combination of external and domestic factors could keep volatility elevated in the near term.

“Indian equities are likely to remain weak in the near term amid renewed uncertainty over a potential resolution of the US-Iran conflict, elevated crude prices and rising global bond yields,” said Siddhartha Khemka, Head of Research, Wealth Management, Motilal Oswal Financial Services Ltd.

SEBI eases settlement, overhauls PMS

Ashokamithran T.
MUMBAI

The Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) okayed new settlement norms aimed at reducing regulatory discretion and making it easier for entities facing enforcement proceedings to settle cases.

The new framework replaces the 2018 Settlement Proceedings Regulations under which certain categories of violations – including those involving significant market impact, substantial investor losses and threats to market integrity – were excluded from

settlement mechanisms.

Addressing concerns over whether the revised framework could allow violators to settle by paying amounts lower than the impact caused by their actions, SEBI Whole-Time Member Kamlesh Varshney said “the philosophy remains the same. The discretion to reject settlement applications still stays with high-powered committee.”

He added the new regulations were aligned with provisions introduced in the Securities Contracts (Regulation) Act, which provide a statutory framework for settlement and re-

lated mechanisms.

New formula

Under the revised rules, SEBI introduced a new formula for calculating settlement amounts. The regulator also created a fast-track mechanism allowing cases to be settled without being referred to the High Powered Committee if the calculated settlement amount is below ₹10 lakh.

The deadline for filing settlement applications has been extended to 90 days from the date of the show-cause notice from the earlier limit of 60 days.

SEBI also approved a

common advertisement code for market intermediaries and regulated entities to simplify and standardising advertising practices across securities market.

SEBI also approved a comprehensive overhaul of the Portfolio Managers Regulations aimed at expanding the portfolio management services (PMS) industry, easing compliance requirements, consolidating regulations and removing outdated provisions.

SEBI's reforms seek to make PMS more competitive by improving operational flexibility and simplifying compliance.

Legal opinion ‘backs’ Chandra’s renewal

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

Legal opinions obtained by Tata Sons support the validity of N. Chandrasekaran's reappointment as chairman for a third five-year term, saying the provision in the company's Articles of Association (AoA) that requires a Selection Committee applies to the appointment of a new chairman and not to the extension or reappointment of an incumbent.

While former Supreme Court judges Justice B.N. Srikrishna and Justice Uday U. Lalit opined the casting vote exercised by the chairman of the Tata Group board was valid under the company's AoA, the September 17 board resolution giving Mr. Chandrasekaran a third term was on lines of a similar one that gave him a second term in 2022.

Justice Srikrishna said the action was consistent



with Article 121, while Justice Lalit said the equality of votes among directors appointed under Article 104B provided an occasion for the chairman to exercise a casting vote.

Tata Trusts, which owns about 66% of Tata Sons, challenged the September 17 board resolution giving Mr. Chandrasekaran a third term arguing that its AoA require affirmative support from a majority of Trust-nominated directors and a chairman's casting vote cannot override that requirement.

MDSL, GSL to boost A.P. shipbuilding plan

V. Raghavendra
VIJAYAWADA

The Andhra Pradesh (A.P.) Government's plan to develop shipbuilding clusters secured a major fillip via tie-ups with the Mumbai-based Mazagon Dock Shipbuilders Ltd. (MDSL) and Goa Shipyard Ltd. (GSL).

This apart, the Kakinada gateway port area is being showcased as another potential location for setting up a shipbuilding unit.

While MDSL has signed a pact with the government for the development of the proposed mega shipbuilding cluster at Dugarajapatnam in Tirupati district earlier this week with an investment of ₹15,000 crore, the State Cabinet on September 23 cleared the setting up of a 400-acre shipbuilding facility at Machilipatnam in partnership with GSL, which committed to invest ₹8,000 crore.

DPR (detailed project report) for Dugarajapat-

The new ports being built in Andhra Pradesh will raise capacity by another 100 million tonne

nam shipbuilding cluster is under preparation and will most probably be ready by end January, A.P. Maritime Board CEO C.V. Praveen Adhithya told *The Hindu*, noting acquisition of about 2,200 acre for this project is in advanced stages.

As far as the Dugarajapatnam project is concerned, MDSL is open to partnerships with global behemoths like HD Hyundai Heavy Industries and Imabari Shipbuilding both for funding and technology deployment.

The existing 'other than major ports' in A.P. are handling 100 million tonne cargo/year and the new ones being built will raise the capacity by another 100 million tonne.

National Wildlife Week

SPECIAL ISSUE

Issue date: 2nd October 2026

- Why do we celebrate National Wildlife Week?
- Spot the common birds in your area.
- Conservation success stories in India.
- The connection between Maths and Nature.
- Guess the animal from the clues given.
- The wild world along India's coastline.
- Activity sheet, folklore, and children's entries.

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Eight killed in wave of Russian drone, missile strikes on Ukraine



Saudi-backed forces repel Houthi militants' push on Taiz-Aden route



'Eight sailors in *USS Lincoln* group attempted suicide on deployment'



Pakistan deploys thousands of security forces ahead of protest



MENTALLY TOUGH

When I compete, I don't know what pain is, says Roshibina



R.V. MOORTHY

Indian wushu player Naorem Roshibina Devi fought the Asian Games title decider with a taped knee and also got hit on the face. “It is just a minor injury. When I am in competition, I forget everything. I am in a different state of mind, I don’t know what pain is,” Roshibina said about the physical discomfort.

ON A ROLL

Dilpreet stars as India crushes Korea 8-2, continues its march



AHF

In-form striker Dilpreet Singh scored a hat-trick as India outclassed Korea 8-2 in a Pool A match of the Asian Games men's hockey competition in Kakamigahara on Thursday. The third consecutive win all but assured the team a place in the semifinal. Defending champion India will next play host Japan on Saturday.

GUTS AND GLORY

Iran's Zarei overcomes wartime adversity, takes home two medals



JONATHAN SELVARAJ

Iranian rower Kimia Zarei overcame wartime disruptions back home in Hamadan to shine at the Asian Games. Zarei and Zeinab Norouzi won gold in women's lightweight double sculls and silver in double sculls. Zarei was forced to train in her room on an ergometer — rowing 20km daily amid the danger of active bombings.

STUNNING PERFORMANCE

Covid no problem for Japanese Ohashi as he breaks World record



AP

Japan's Shin Ohashi shrugged off a bout of Covid to smash the men's 200m breaststroke World record in a time of 2:04.83s at the Asian Games on Thursday. The 17-year-old won his second gold of the Games despite running a temperature of about 39 degrees just days before the competition began.

Persistence and drama on display as mixed relay team, Seema win medals

The 4x400m quartet of Vishal, Poovamma, Manu and Vithya earns silver while Seema, competing in her maiden Asiad, bags bronze in 10,000m

ASIAN GAMES

Uthra Ganesan
NAGOYA

Thirty minutes of persistence on the track followed by three of absolute drama saw day one of track and field competition end with a bronze and silver for India as the country opened its athletics medal tally here on Thursday.

The 4x400m mixed relay team rode on tactical personnel changes, impressive lead-off and anchor legs and a stroke of luck to finish in 3:14.46, earning silver in the final event of the day at the Paloma Mizuho stadium.

Ending a drought

Minutes before, Seema had ended a 16-year drought in 10,000m, willing herself past the line in 32:50.05 to come third.

The Indian quartet of Vishal T.K. — India's only sub-45 second quartermiler — M.R. Poovamma, Manu T.S. and Vithya Ramraj played their roles to per-



Keeping the flag flying: The relay team and Seema brought cheer to the India camp with podium finishes. R.V. MOORTHY

fection. Vishal ran with blistering pace before Poovamma and Manu ensured the team did not fall too far behind.

Vithya, the only surviving member from the team that won silver in 2023, kicked in an extra gear, edging past Vietnam by a mere 0.08 seconds.

Interestingly, India was

second in its heat in the morning, clocking 3:16.23, but replaced Jay Kumar and Kiran with Vishal and Vithya for the final.

The UAE, which had led for a large part of the race, fumbled towards the end, Mariam Kareem dropping the baton just before the final lap. She did try to retrieve it and complete but

the team was disqualified by the officials. Bahrain, led by the indefatigable Salwa Eid Naser, retained top spot with a new Games record of 3:12.87.

Seema, meanwhile, became only the third Indian woman to medal in 10,000m at the Asian Games, after Preeja Sreedharan and Kavita



Raut's historic gold-silver double back in 2010.

The 25-year-old, competing in her first Asiad, was impressive as much in her endurance to keep pace with the lead group as her race intelligence.

“At one point, I thought I could go for the win, but I could not push as hard as the others did. But now I

have begun understanding the tactics and race strategy. I will use my learning from here in 5000m,” she added.

Triple jumper Asha Ilango suffered a heartbreak, coming fourth despite a best of 13.83m — it was the same as Li Yi of China but the Indian missed out on countback.

Bronze for Satnam and Salman

Jonathan Selvaraj
NAGOYA

At the end of the men's double sculls event at the 2026 Asian Games, Salman Khan had his burly hand held up by a volunteer as he navigated the short, 10-foot ramp out of the water on trembling legs.

Satnam Singh couldn't even do that.

They completed the race in 6:13.25s, just under three seconds behind second-placed Uzbekistan pair of Mekhrojbek Mamatkulov and Pavel Sorin. China's Yi Xudi, Nie Yide (6:09.77) won the gold.

Even as he lay on his back, Satnam cried out: “Gold chala gaya (we lost the gold).”

As uncharitable as they were to themselves, the two had still made history.



Gritty display: Salman and Satnam became the first Indian duo to land a medal in men's double sculls. PTI

Not only were they the first Indian duo to achieve a podium finish in this event in the Games history, they were also the only Indian rowers to win a medal in Nagoya.

It's almost a miracle that they did.

They were meant to take part in the men's quadruple sculls, considered the marquee event.

Then, two days before the start of their competition, the rowing federation decided to split up India's settled pairings. Satnam and Salman were moved to the double sculls, an event they had never competed in together.

With next to no preparation, they took to the course on Thursday morning and delivered in style.

Anantjeet-Parinaaz duo clinches bronze medal

Uthra Ganesan
NAGOYA

The shotgun contingent saved the blushes yet again for Indian shooting on a day the pistol team drew a blank at the Aichi General Shooting Range here on Thursday, with the country still waiting for its maiden gold in the sport.

Anantjeet Singh Naruka, having missed an individual medal by the narrowest of margins on Wednesday, teamed up with Parinaaz Dhaliwal to win bronze in mixed team skeet, the country's first-ever in the event at the Asian Games. The men's 10m air pistol squad, however, disappointed with all three not making the final and also failing to bag a team medal. India had won the team gold in the previous edition.

Kamaljeet, Aakash Bhardwaj and Kedarling Uchaganve stumbled while the trio stood fourth. Kamaljeet came the closest, finishing ninth with 580 points, just one off the final qualification spot. Having started well and scored a perfect 100 in his third series, Kamaljeet had poor rounds of 94 and 93 that affected his chances of advancing.

Bhardwaj shot 579 to come 11th. Uchaganve had a forgettable outing, finishing 35th with a total of 568.



Bright spot: Anantjeet and Parinaaz shone on an otherwise disappointing day for India at the shooting range. PTI

The combined score of 1727 was not enough to go past Japan: Uchaganve's last series of 92 allowed the hosts to jump to third and complete the podium with 1730 points.

Anantjeet and Parinaaz, meanwhile, started slow in qualification with a 44 in the opening round before scoring 47 each in the next two to make the final with 138 points, one point ahead of Kuwait. The final saw a close battle before India and Korea shot identical 44 points, the Koreans edging ahead by virtue of their higher finish in the

qualifying phase.

“We had a difficult start: both of us didn't shoot well in the first round but we told each other that we can still get it. We wanted to fight till the last target and that's what we did,” Anantjeet said. “We both are aggressive and rhythmic shooters, so it just works quite well. He is shooting ahead of me, so I see that and it gives me that recall,” Parinaaz said.

The pistol squad had its first victim with Kamaljeet replacing Uchaganve in the mixed team event to partner Suruchi Phogat.

INDIANS IN ACTION TODAY

A look at some Indian players/teams who will compete on Friday (all times IST):

Athletics: Women's heptathlon (Anamika, Pooja), 6.30 a.m. onwards; Women's shot put final (Manpreet, Krishna), 3.35 p.m.; Women's pole vault final (Sindhushree, Baranika), 4.30 p.m.; Women's 400m heats (Kiran, Prachi), 5.50 p.m.; Men's 100m semifinals (Gurindervir, Animesh), 4 p.m.; final, 6.50 p.m.; Men's 10,000m final (Gulveer), 5 p.m.; Men's hammer throw final (Damneet, Praveen), 5.10 p.m.; Men's 400m heats (Vishal), 6.20 p.m.

Badminton: First round: Mixed doubles: Dhruv & Tanisha vs. Nibal & Aminath (Mdv), 6.10 a.m.; Men's doubles (not before 4 p.m.); Satwiksairaj & Chirag vs. Pakkapon & Peeratchai (Tha); Hariharan & Arjun vs. Fajar & Shohibul (Ina).

Boxing: Round-of-16: Men's 60kg: Sachin vs. Jajeh (Jor), 10.15 a.m.; Women's 54kg: Preeti vs. Mi (PRK), 2.15 p.m.

Fencing: Table-of-16: Men's foil team: vs. Hong Kong, 6 a.m.; Women's epee team: vs. Uzbekistan, 7 a.m.

Hockey: Women (Pool B): vs. Japan, 7.30 a.m.

Kabaddi: Semifinals: Women: vs. Nepal (9.30 a.m.); Men: vs. Thailand (10.45 a.m.).

Shooting: 10m air pistol mixed team qualification (Suruchi &

Kamaljeet), 6.15 a.m.; final, 8.30 a.m.; 50m rifle 3P men individual qualification and team final (Aishwary Pratap, Rudranksh, Niraj), 7.15 a.m.; individual final, 10.30 a.m.

Squash: Quarterfinals: Mixed doubles: Velavan & Joshna vs. Pelino & Aribado (Phi), 7 a.m.; Men: Abhay vs. Tsukue (Jpn), 9.15 a.m.; Veer vs. Irfan (Pak), 10.45 a.m.; Women: Anahat vs. Tanvi, 10 a.m.

Swimming: Heats (from 6.30 a.m.): Men: 50m breaststroke (Danush), 200m backstroke (Rishabh, Utkarsh); 400m freestyle (Dhakshan, Aneesh); 200m butterfly (Sajan); finals (from 1.30 p.m.).

Table tennis: Mixed doubles (quarterfinals): Manush & Diya vs. Ting & Kem (Hkg) and Harmeet & Yashaswini vs. Lin & Kuai (Chn), both at 6.30 a.m.; Men's doubles: Round 2: Harmeet & Sathivan vs. Affan & Negara (Ina), 7.30 a.m.; Manav & Manush vs. Tomokazu & Hiroto (Jpn), 8.15 a.m.; Women: Round 2: Yashaswini vs. Zaza (Syr), 9 a.m.; Sreeja vs. Gyong (PRK), 9.45 a.m.; Men: Round 2: Manav vs. Ryong (PRK), 10.30 a.m.; Manush vs. Faraji (Iri), 11.15 a.m.; Women's doubles: Round 3: Sreeja & Syndrela vs. Kuai & Wang (Chn), noon; Yashaswini & Diya vs. Shuhan & Yi (Chn), 12.45 p.m.

Weightlifting: Women's 61kg final (Nirupama), 1.30 p.m.

THE INDIA SHOW

A look at some Indian performances on Thursday:

Athletics: Women's 10,000m final: Seema (bronze); Women's triple jump final: Asha (fourth), Niharika (10th); 4x400m mixed relay: Silver; Men's 100m heats: Animesh (third in heat 1) and Gurindervir (second in heat 4), both qualified for the semifinals.

Boxing: Round-of-16: Men: 70kg: Sumit lost to Al-Sarray (Irq); Women: 51kg: Sakshi lost to Balkibekova (Kaz); 65kg: Parveen w/o Nozimova (Tjk).

Fencing: Table-of-16: Women's sabre individual: Bhavani Devi lost to Xueyi (Chn) 5-15; Shreya lost to Jeon (Kor) 6-15.

Gymnastics: Women's vault

final: Pranati (sixth).

Hockey: Men (Pool A): bt South Korea 8-2.

Kabaddi: Men (Group A): bt Taiwan 37-21; Women (Group A): bt Japan 50-25.

Rowing: Final: Men: Double sculls: Satnam & Salman (bronze); Single sculls: Balraj (fourth); Lightweight double sculls: Rohit & Ujjwal (fourth).

Shooting: Skeet mixed team final: Parinaaz & Anantjeet (bronze); 10m air pistol men individual qualification: Kamaljeet (ninth), Aakash (11th) and Kedarling (35th), all DNQ for final; Team final: Fourth.

Squash: Round-of-16: Men: Abhay bt Laksiri (SL) 3-0; Veer bt

Sanjay (Mas) 3-2; Women: Tanvi bt Yhann (Sgp) 3-1; Anahat bt Lynn (Sgp) 3-0; Mixed doubles: Velavan & Joshna bt Suraj & Shameena 2-0.

Swimming: Men: 800m freestyle final: Aryan (11th overall); 50m butterfly: Benedicton (joint 12th overall), DNQ for final; 4x100m freestyle relay: 12th overall, DNQ for final.

Table tennis: Men (round 1): Manush bt Wong (Mas) 4-0; Women's doubles (round 2): Yashaswini & Diya bt Setayesh & Mahshid (Iri) 3-0; Sreeja & Syndrela bt Bolor-Erdene & Burenjargal (Mgl) 3-0.

Wushu: Women's sanda 60kg final: Roshibina lost to Zhang (Chn).

INBRIEF



Breetzke ton, Maharaj four-for headline South Africa’s win

Matthew Breetzke’s century and a four-wicket haul by Keshav Maharaj helped South Africa outplay Australia by 67 runs in the first ODI at Durban on Thursday. Chasing a target of 298, the visitor lost its last nine wickets for 101 runs to be bowled out for 230 in the 42nd over.

The scores: South Africa 297/8 in 50 overs (Breetzke 112, Jansen 75) bt Australia 230 in 41.2 overs (Marsh 60, Renshaw 44, Maharaj 4/20). **Toss:** Australia; **PoM:** Breetzke.



India finishes 11th in 100km World championships

India finished 11th among 42 nations in the IAU 100km World championships atyn Ames, Spain, recently, with the men recording their best performance. India was ranked second among Asian countries. Amar Singh Devandaa created a new National record, clocking six hours, 49 minutes and 17 seconds, to improve on his own mark set last year.



WPL 2027: Luke Williams named MI head coach

Mumbai Indians on Thursday appointed Luke Williams as its head coach after parting ways with Lisa Keightley ahead of the Women’s Premier League 2027. “We have a great opportunity to build something together, play exciting cricket and compete for success,” said Williams. He had worked as the chief coach of Royal Challengers Bengaluru during its maiden title triumph in 2024. The Mumbai franchise had won the WPL crown in 2023 and 2025 while losing the Eliminator once.

Ragul slams 179 as Tirupur books a final with Coimbatore

S.P. Ragul Rithick scored 179 and stitched an opening-wicket stand of 243 with R. Sree Shivaji (95) as Tirupur thrashed Kancheepuram by 166 runs in the semifinal of the TNCA under-23 inter-district tournament in Coimbatore on Thursday. Tirupur will take on Coimbatore, which scored an eight-wicket win over Tenkasi, in Friday’s final.

The scores (semifinals): Tenkasi 73 in 27.5 overs (Thasish Kannan 4/9, R. Kirubakar 3/9) lost to Coimbatore 74/2 in 13.5 overs (G. Siddharth 37 n.o., R. Kishore 32). Tirupur 347/7 in 50 overs (S.P. Ragul Rithick 179, R. Sree Shivaji 95, S. Muthukumar 3/67) bt Kancheepuram 181 in 36.4 overs (T.M. Kavin 59, A. Sharvin 30 n.o., S.J. Arun Kumar 3/18, S. Pavish 5/37).

The champion



On top: SRM IST, which won the gold in the State-level inter-institution volleyball tournament, organised by Hindustan University. Tamil Nadu Sports University finished runner-up. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

LIVE TELECAST

Asian Games: Cricket (Men), Sony Sports Ten 1 & LIV, 10.30 a.m. & 5.30 a.m. (Saturday)
Formula One: Azerbaijan GP (Qualifying), F1 TV, F1 TV Pro App & FanCode, 5.30 p.m.
Football: Nations League, Sony Sports Ten 1, 2, 5 & LIV, 9.30 p.m. & 12.15 a.m. (Saturday)
Asian Games: Sony Sports Ten 5 & LIV, 5.30 a.m. (Saturday).

A chance for India to evaluate standing against the elite as it meets Panama

Coach Jamil will look to use the friendly against the central Americans to expose the players to the demands of the game at the top level



Testing time: The series of friendlies will be a learning curve for Jamil and his team. K. MURALI KUMAR

FOOTBALL

Ashwin Achal
BENGALURU

India faces Panama at the Sree Kanteerava Stadium on Friday in an international football friendly that marks the beginning of a rare sequence of high-profile fixtures. Over the next fortnight, the national team will take on three teams that featured at the 2026 FIFA World Cup – Panama, Brazil and Uruguay. These outings offers the Indian team an understanding of where it stands against the international elite. India coach Khalid Jamil will look to expose his

players to the pace, intensity and tactical demands of top-level football. But Jamil will also have to contend with rustiness, with the Indian Super League yet to begin and several players short of competitive match practice. Experienced goalkeeper Gurpreet Singh Sandhu remains an important figure. Anirudh Thapa’s ability to dictate play from midfield and Ryan Williams’ direct running could be crucial. Jamil could be tempted to adopt a cautious approach and defend in numbers. When opportunities arise on the counter, however, Williams and Manvir Singh will have to make their count. Panama, ranked 44th in the world, poses a mighty challenge. Its campaign in the World Cup ended in the group stage following defeats to Ghana, Croatia and England, but for the tiny Central American nation to reach the grandest stage is in itself a commendable achievement. With 14 members of the Panama squad having featured in the World Cup campaign, there is plenty of quality in the visitor camp. The first examination of the gulf between Indian football and the international elite begins on Friday. Five-time World Cup winner Brazil (on October 3) and Uruguay (October 6) will raise the bar considerably higher.

We have to gain something out of these friendlies: Gurpreet

Ashwin Achal
BENGALURU

When it was announced that India would face big names Panama, Brazil and Uruguay in succession, it took goalkeeper Gurpreet Singh Sandhu by surprise. “It was unexpected, to be honest. Like everyone else, we wanted to see if this was actually happening,” Gurpreet said on the eve of the India-Panama clash here. Now that these high-profile matches are a reality, the shotstopper is keen to make the most of them. “We must make sure that we use this opportunity to



Gurpreet. K. MURALI KUMAR

gain something out of it. On paper, these games look really good because of

the opponents we are facing. But every single game is special when you get to play for your country. It does not matter who we face. We want to win,” Gurpreet said. Head coach Khalid Jamil defended the exclusion of senior players Sandesh Jhingan and Lallianzuala Chhangte, stating that he intends to put together a “new team”. “Yes, I have left some seniors out, but it does not mean that they cannot make a comeback. We are thinking about building a new team. We have young players who need to play more matches,” Jamil said.

Showtime



Legends in focus: All eyes will once again be on Rohit Sharma and Virat Kohli as India takes on West Indies in a three-match ODI series which begins on September 27 in Thiruvananthapuram. The next two games will be played on September 30 (Guwahati) and October 3 (New Chandigarh). NIRMAL HARINDRAN



Savitha saves the day for Indian women; open team held

CHESS OLYMPIAD

Sports Bureau

A late equaliser from B. Savitha Shri helped the Indian women draw with Kazakhstan in the Chess Olympiad on Thursday. The men’s team also was held to a draw by Azerbaijan at Samarkand. With the tournament in its business-end, it indeed was not ideal for India, the defending champion in both the sections. It could, of course, have been much worse if Savitha hadn’t been able to pull off that hard-fought win against Elnaz Kaliakhmet. The 19-year-old from Chennai has been having a dream Olympiad debut in Uzbekistan. She has won all her seven games and is well poised to win an indi-



Unstoppable: Savitha continued a dream Olympiad debut by beating Kaliakhmet for her seventh win on the trot. FIDE

vidual medal regardless of how her team fares. She was in a must-win situation on this day, as India was trailing 1-2, thanks to R. Vaishali’s loss to Alua Nur-

man on the second board. Koneru Humpy and Divya Deshmukh had drawn their games. It was a drawn rook-pawn ending, but once Kaliakhmet erred, Savitha ensured she converted the advantage and won in 62 moves. That earned India a precious match point and now has 13 points, two less than sole leader China. On 14 points are Kazakhstan, Armenia and Mongolia. In the open section, India is joint second with 13 points, one behind the leaders Uzbekistan and Germany. All the Indian players drew with their Azerbaijan rivals. The day’s biggest upset

was provided by Germany, which won 2.5-1.5 against Uzbekistan which opens up the race to the top. Three more rounds remain. **Important results (eighth round): Open: India drew with Azerbaijan 2-2** (R. Praggnanandhaa drew with Shakhriyar Mamedyarov; Arjun Eriagisi drew with Aydin Suleymanli; D. Gukesh drew with Mahammad Muradli; Vidit Gujrathi drew with Rauf Mamedov). Germany bt Uzbekistan 2.5-1.5; Armenia drew with Netherlands 2-2; USA bt Serbia 3.5-0.5; China bt Poland 2.5-1.5; Czech Republic drew with Hungary 2-2; France bt Iran 2.5-1.5; Uzbekistan (2) bt England 2.5-1.5; Ukraine bt Belarus 2.5-1.5; Spain bt

Montenegro 2.5-1.5; Turkiye bt Canada 2.5-1.5; Greece bt Moldova 3-1; Israel drew with Vietnam 2-2. **Women: India drew with Kazakhstan 2-2** (Bibisara Assaubayeva drew with Koneru Humpy; R. Vaishali lost to Alua Nurman; Divya Deshmukh drew with Meruert Kamalidenova; B. Savitha Shri bt Elnaz Kaliakhmet). Uzbekistan bt Netherlands 3-1; China bt Georgia 2.5-1.5; Mongolia bt Bulgaria 2.5-1.5; Armenia bt USA 2.5-1.5; Greece bt Ukraine 2.5-1.5; Argentina drew with Azerbaijan 2-2; France bt Italy 3.5-0.5; Poland bt Iran 2.5-1.5; Germany bt Austria 2.5-1.5; Belarus bt Serbia 2.5-1.5; Indonesia bt Switzerland 2.5-1.5; Czech Republic drew with Hungary 2-2; Canada bt Spain 3-1.

Russell pushes leader Antonelli to second in Azerbaijan practice

FORMULA ONE

Agence France-Presse
BAKU

George Russell topped the times ahead of teammate and World championship leader Kimi Antonelli as Mercedes dominated Friday’s second practice for the Azerbaijan Grand Prix. The pair delivered a 1-2 as Russell completed a Friday ‘double top’ ahead of Red Bull’s four-time World champion Max Verstappen by eight-tenths of a second. Russell was fastest in one minute and 43.347 seconds to outpace his Italian partner by 0.552sec in

a convincing display of speed on the fast and unforgiving barrier-lined streets of Azerbaijan capital. Charles Leclerc was fourth ahead of his Ferrari team-mate seven-time World champion Lewis Hamilton, with reigning World champion Lando Norris sixth for McLaren ahead of Alpine’s Pierre Gasly and his McLaren teammate Oscar Piastri. Isack Hadjar was ninth in the second Red Bull, having returned to action after breaking his wrist. Several drivers survived narrow escapes from brushes with the barriers and walls.

Wrestler Deepak seeks urgent hearing

Y.B. Sarangi
KOLKATA

Hoping to be included in the Asian Games-bound Indian contingent in the last minute, Greco-Roman wrestler Deepak (67kg), who was removed from the squad after testing positive for banned substance Clomifene, on Thursday approached NADA seeking an expedited hearing of his case. The Indian wrestling squad is all set to leave for Japan on Saturday. Deepak returned a positive result for Clomifene in a test conducted during the Asian Games trials in Lucknow on May 31.

TNCA LEAGUE

Jeeva’s century highlights Prem’s win C. Jeeva slammed 109 as Prem CC scored a 54-run win over TSRMSC in a TNCA III-B league match recently. **The scores:** **III-B:** Prem 239/7 in 45 overs (S. Ahmed Batsha 49, C. Jeeva 109, R. Thavith Kumar 4/46) bt TSRMSC 185 in 36.2 overs (Adhithya Giridhar 39, M. Sridhar Raj 36, S. Kishan Kumar 43, B. Arvind 4/23, C. Shriram 3/31). **Match reduced to 45 overs.** **IV-B:** Kovai Knights 208/8 in 38 overs (K. Narasimhan 58, S. Gohulmoorthi 39, T.G. Ashwin Narayanan 4/46, R. Vineeth 4/57) bt Jubilee 182 in 36.1 overs (P. Thanikachalam 67, C.R. Sriram Prasad 30, R. Rohith Ram 6/53). **Match reduced to 38 overs.** **IV-C:** GE T&D India 155 in 43.4 overs (M. Niruban Kumar 38, R. Hiruthick 3/27) bt Tiger 76 in 27.2 overs (Ambrish Rangan 3/21). **Match reduced to 44 overs.**



Jeeva (Prem, 109); Rohith (Kovai Knights, 6/53)



Thamilarasu (AISC, 5/14); Balasubramani (Presidency College, 5/27).

VI-A: Pegasus 74 in 28.5 overs (Lakshmanan 3/10) lost to Cosmopolitan Club 75/1 in 12.1 overs (S. Vignesh 62 n.o.). Halifaxes 163/7 in 30 overs (P. Karthik 67 n.o., M. Kailash 3/49) bt YMCA, Royapettah 127 in 26.5 overs (K. Sampath Kumar 42, M.

Tharun 3/33). Amar 167/7 in 30 overs (Bharath Sivakumar 32, Karampal Jangra 42, V.C. Prasanth 3/37) bt Bank of India 127 in 28.4 overs (S. Nishanth 35, V.C. Prasanth 34, P. Dinesh Kumar 4/27, R. Rajkumar 3/19). **VI-B:** Ashok Leyland 81/9 in 25 overs (Thamilarasu Ravichandran 5/14) lost to AISC 82/3 in 16.1 overs (Chandru 32). **Match reduced to 25 overs.** MFL 108/8 in 30 overs (Johnson Peter Xavier 34) lost to Jai Hind 109/2 in 24.1 overs (B. Sanjai 57 n.o., S. Maharish 46). Chennai Corporation 206 in 29.4 overs (M. Bharath 99, R. Balasubramani 5/27, Tiraj Sanjay 4/54) bt Presidency College 73 in 24.3 overs (A. Srinivasan 3/10, V. Yuvaraj 3/19, D. Vinobhaji 3/21). Eccentrics 141 in 24.5 overs (S. Rahul Kanna 30 n.o., V. Nitin Rose 4/44, Rohit Tiwari 4/13) lost to IAF (Tbm) 142/6 in 27.2 overs (Naveen Singh Bisht 41 ret.d. hurt, V. Sriram 3/36).



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Agarkar's roller-coaster ride

When the former pacer was named the chairman of selectors in July 2023, there was a sense of great optimism and feel-good; his tenure, however, was a chequered one with highs in the white-ball format and lows in the Tests



AFP

R. Kaushik

From all indications, BCCI senior chief selector Ajit Agarkar has chaired his last selection committee meeting. A little over a week back, the Agarkar-led panel picked the national squads to do duty against West Indies in three One-Day Internationals and five Twenty20 Internationals, apart from naming the Rest of India side to take on Ranji Trophy champions Jammu & Kashmir in the Irani Cup.

Among those named in the ODI squad was Rohit Sharma, the former captain whose future has been needlessly put under the microscope over the last 12 months. It is widely perceived that Rohit has inadvertently become the primary reason for Agarkar choosing, as is being touted, not to seek an extension to his term as chairman of selectors when his tenure ends early next week.

Good rapport

When Agarkar was named the chairman in July 2023, there was a sense of great optimism and feel-good. He had played alongside Rohit, by then firmly entrenched as the all-format skipper, as well as head coach Rahul Dravid. He shared a good rapport with the two men that formed the core leadership group, and it was widely anticipated that this troika would work in tandem to push Indian cricket further ahead on the path to dominance.

The honeymoon period lasted for a fair while, it can't be disputed. Under Rohit, India charged through to the final of the home 50-over World Cup in 2023 before coming a cropper in the title round against Australia, then mounted a flawless, unbeaten campaign in the Americas as they won a second T20 World Cup crown in Bridgetown in June 2024. In some ways, that victory was to prove a decisive moment in Indian cricket, and not necessarily for the reasons one might consider organic or positive.

Dravid's tenure as head coach ended with India's defeat to Australia, before he was persuaded by the Board of Control for Cricket in India and, more decisively, by a phone call from Rohit, to stay on till the end of the T20 World Cup. That proved to be a masterstroke; Rohit and Dravid realised there was unfinished business to address, and while the T20 World Cup might not hold the same aura as its more established white-ball counterpart, it was immensely satisfying for the two driven men that, finally, they had worthwhile silverware to show for their hegemony, hard work and entertaining, aggressive brand of cricket.

As Dravid walked away into the sunset and V.V.S. Laxman expressed his inability to take over as head coach, the BCCI's hunt for a successor to the Bengalurean ended with Gautam Gambhir, the pugnacious former opener with a feisty, confrontational streak. Gambhir came with his own set of ideas. Unstated but perhaps somewhere near the top of that list was a desire to put together a new, young Test team that didn't have a place at some stage in the not-too-distant future for Rohit, his predecessor Virat Kohli and off-spinning giant R. Ashwin.

The first seeds of discontent were sowed in Gambhir's second series in



Agarkar and Laxman... communication lines blurred? FILE PHOTO: N. SRIDHARAN N. SRIDHARAN

charge, at home against New Zealand in October-November 2024. India were crushed 0-3, their first home series loss in more than a decade, and the finger-pointing began almost immediately.

Within months of that debacle, the celebrated trio had played its last Tests at different times on the subsequent tour of Australia, which India lost 1-3. Rohit missed the first game, victory in Perth, as he was away on paternity leave, and when he rejoined the team, his form deserted him summarily. Ashwin retired midway through the series, Rohit dropped himself for the final game in Sydney owing to poor form and Kohli's tour unravelling dramatically after an unbeaten second-innings hundred in Perth as he unerringly found the slip cordon time after time.

Thorny transition

Rohit and Kohli announced their retirement from Test cricket within a week of each other in May 2025. By this time, Gambhir and Agarkar had already embarked on the tricky path to transition. To lose three giants in one fell swoop isn't easy to recover from. Agarkar's panel had its work cut out but it showed gumption and a propensity to go with its gut by naming Shubman Gill as the Test captain.

Gill's first assignment was an away tour of England, where he showed sensational form and reasonably promising tactical awareness in securing a fabulous 2-2 stalemate. The captain led from the front with four hundreds, including a monumental 269 in Birmingham, on his way to 754 dazzling runs and eked out fantastic returns from Mohammed Siraj and Prasidh Krishna as both of India's victories came when Jasprit Bumrah was rested to manage his workload.

Agarkar's panel bared its intentions when it brought Gill back into the T20I setup -- as the vice-captain to Suryakumar Yadav, no less -- and thrust him into the hot-seat in the ODI format too last October. Between the Australia Test series and IPL 2025, during the course of which Rohit and Kohli announced their Test retirements, India had won five matches on the trot to storm to the Champions' Trophy title in the desert sands of Dubai in March.

Rohit had masterminded that charge with aplomb, using his bat as a scything weapon and leading with characteristic nous and acumen, but in a clear indication that he was on borrowed time, Agarkar and his men believed a change in leadership was imperative with the next 50-over World Cup two years away.

Steadfast, dignified silence

From that point, Rohit has been a marked man, his every move dissected, his every ODI series touted as his international swansong. All of a sudden, from being the most important man in Indian cricket, he was put in a difficult place, almost having to 'prove' himself time after time. To his credit, the Mumbaier has maintained a steadfast, dignified silence -- much like he did when he was summarily divested of the Mumbai Indians captaincy a couple of years back even though he had led the franchise to five titles -- and allowed his bat to do the talking.

The last straw, the consensus is, in the Agarkar vs. Rohit saga -- a saga unfolding in social media and on the internet and in reams of newsprint -- came in England in July. Ostensibly, Rohit had been asked to announce his retirement at the end of the three-match series, after the final game at Lord's. In the lead-up to the last ODI, epitaphs were being written, cryptic posts appeared on social media platforms and it was more or less accepted that Rohit wouldn't play for the country again, until, in an unprecedented move, BCCI secretary Devajit Saikia voluntarily declared that Lord's would not be Rohit's swansong.

Clearly, that hasn't gone down well with Agarkar, and understandably so. Selection matters are the prerogative of the selectors, specifically appointed for that sole purpose. If the BCCI wanted Rohit to continue, the secretary or the office-bearers could have had a word in private with Agarkar to express their stance. The public declaration, without provocation, raised Agarkar's hackles and his relationship with the BCCI, it is presumed, soured from that point in mid-July onwards.

Notwithstanding the unseemly haste in trying to get rid of one of the greatest white-ball practitioners of all time,

Agarkar had reason to feel miffed, if not downright insulted. But he didn't cover himself in glory by not attending the review meeting called by the BCCI in Mumbai at the beginning of this month. By now, it was evident that things had reached a point of no-return, and even though Saikia made a spirited defence of the Agarkar no-show by citing personal reasons, no one had any doubts that the die had been cast.

If Agarkar does bow out, his report card will be a mixed bag. During his 38-month tenure, India won two T20 World Cups, two Asia Cups (one each in the 50- and the 20-over formats) and made it to the final of the 50-over World Cup at home. But their Test record has been abysmal -- home series routs by New Zealand and South Africa (2-0 last November), and an away series loss to Australia in 2024-25 (1-3) completely cancel out all else, including a 1-0 victory in Sri Lanka last month.

Left-field decision

India have stuttered and stumbled in the transition phase, especially when it comes to bowling, and there has been a certain ambivalence in white-ball selection. The return of Shreyas Iyer to the T20I ecosystem after three years, in the role of captain, is as much of a left-field decision as the hasty call-up and dumping of Gill from the same version last year. From the days when Indian squads looked settled and were fuelled by consistency in selection, there is a sense of insecurity and of nervously looking over one's shoulder, which is fair from the ideal scenario in which anyone can give off their best.

There have been reports of a breakdown in communication between Agarkar and Laxman, the head of the Centre of Excellence, especially when it comes to picking India 'A' squads. The CoE has chalked out long-standing pathways to prepare the next set of emerging talent for international cricket, but the selection panel has often chosen to override that pathway and thrust established Indian Test players into the mix, ostensibly for match practice, even in familiar home conditions. It is reliably learnt that Laxman wasn't even consulted when the selectors picked the squad for the Asian Games though it was clear many months back that he would be the coach in Aichi-Nagoya. So much for transparency and openness isn't a quip without substance.

Should events unfold along expected lines, India will have a new chairman very soon. They must too, because the squads for the tour of New Zealand, beginning with the first of five T20Is in Christchurch on October 22, need to be picked; the team is expected to depart from Bengaluru on October 18. The T20Is will be followed by five ODIs, the first phase of the final leg of preparations for the World Cup, and two Tests. Whoever the new chairman is -- for now, the needle points in the direction of former India stumper Parthiv Patel, who led unfancied Gujarat to the Ranji Trophy title in January 2017 -- will first have to ensure an equanimous relationship with the two captains and the head coach to ensure that the winds of uncertainty threatening to sweep through the cricketing landscape are calmed, if not quelled, post haste.

THE GIST

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HEALTH

When cancer treatment is no longer working

Modern oncology has transformed countless lives. Yet an important gap remains. We do not prepare patients and their families for uncertainty. What happens if the treatment stops helping? How much should the patient know? When should children be told? How do we decide what matters most now?

V. Divya Sai

The hardest conversation in cancer care rarely begins with the words, “There is nothing more we can do.” It usually begins much earlier. “Should we tell him?” “Can we try one more treatment?” “Will she lose hope if she knows?”

These questions are asked quietly: in hospital corridors, outside intensive care units, or after doctors have left the room. They are spoken in whispers because families are not simply making medical decisions; they are trying to protect someone they love.

As a palliative medicine physician working alongside oncology teams, I have learned that when treatment is no longer working as expected, families often find themselves facing conversations they never imagined having. The challenge is not only accepting that the disease has changed; it is learning how to talk about what comes next.

Conversations we prepare least for

Modern oncology has transformed countless lives. New drugs, targeted therapies, immunotherapy and better supportive care have helped many people live longer than ever before. Yet an important gap remains.

We prepare families remarkably well for chemotherapy schedules, blood tests and scan reports. We prepare them far less for conversations about uncertainty. What happens if the treatment stops helping? How much should the patient know? When should children be told? How do we decide what matters most now?

These questions do not signal that hope has disappeared. They signal that hope is changing.

A young man I recently cared for had advanced blood cancer and was admitted to the ICU with severe pain. Over the next few days, his greatest distress was not only physical. Watching critically ill patients around him, he became convinced that he would be next. When he finally asked, “Am I going to die?” he was not asking for a statistical answer. He was asking whether someone would help him understand what was happening.

Another family kept asking whether there was “one last option.” As our conversation unfolded, it became clear that they were not asking for another medicine. They wanted enough time to gather siblings from different cities, celebrate one more birthday together, and prepare for conversations they had



Care that continues: Patients frequently sense when their condition is changing, even when nobody says it directly. Silence can sometimes create greater fear than truth because people begin imagining conversations they are not allowed to have. GETTY IMAGES

been postponing. Often, the real question is different from the one being asked aloud.

Weaving honesty and hope

Many families worry that honest conversations will extinguish hope. In reality, compassionate communication does not require choosing between honesty and kindness. Patients frequently sense when their condition is changing, even when nobody says it directly. Silence can sometimes create greater fear than truth because people begin imagining conversations they are not allowed to have.

Good communication means understanding how much information a patient wishes to receive, respecting cultural and family dynamics, and revisiting discussions as situations evolve. It is rarely a single conversation. More often, it is a series of conversations built on trust. Hope also evolves. Early in illness, hope may mean cure. Later, it may mean attending a daughter's wedding, spending time at home instead of the hospital, sleeping through the night without pain, or simply being able to share one meaningful conversation with a loved one.

One of the biggest misconceptions is

Good communication means understanding how much information a patient wishes to receive, respecting cultural and family dynamics, and revisiting discussions as situations evolve

that palliative care begins only after treatment ends.

In reality, it works alongside cancer treatment by helping patients manage pain, breathlessness, nausea, anxiety, fatigue and caregiver distress while supporting difficult decision-making. Some of the most meaningful palliative care conversations happen while patients are still receiving active treatment. Instead of asking only, “What is the next treatment?”, we also ask: “What matters most to you?”; “What are you hoping for?” and “What are you worried about?”

These questions often reveal priorities that laboratory values never can.

Here are some conversations families should not delay having with loved ones who have cancer. When facing advanced cancer, especially, these discussions are easier before a crisis occurs: Ask what the patient wants to know about their illness. Discuss goals that matter to them beyond

treatment. Talk about symptom control early rather than waiting for unbearable pain. Identify who should make decisions if the patient cannot. Ask for a palliative care consultation early-alongside oncology-not only during the final days.

These conversations are not about giving up. They are about giving families the chance to make decisions with clarity instead of panic.

There is one moment I return to often. A family once told me, after losing someone they loved, “We don't remember every medicine that was given. We remember that she wasn't in pain, that we were able to sit together, and that we got to say goodbye.”

Years later, families rarely remember every chemotherapy cycle. They remember whether someone explained what was happening; whether suffering was relieved; whether they felt alone. Perhaps that is the real purpose of these conversations. Not to predict the future; not to remove grief: but to ensure that even when treatment changes, care never does.

(Dr. V. Divya Sai is a palliative medicine specialist at MNJ Institute of Oncology & Regional Cancer Centre, Hyderabad. vdivyasai22@gmail.com)

THE GIST

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BIG SHOT



Ground zero: A child being vaccinated at a health camp setup by a mobile boat clinic in the Barballa river island in Nalbari district of Assam. Several people in Assam live on “chars”, or temporary river islands and sandbars where access to even basic healthcare can be a challenge. AFP

GERD is more than just heartburn: why it is important to understand the difference

Athira Elssa Johnson

Heartburn is commonly described as acidity and treated with antacids.

But gastro-oesophageal reflux disease (GERD) is not simply acidity. It occurs when the stomach contents repeatedly move into the oesophagus because the normal anti-reflux barrier does not function effectively.

“GERD is not simply a problem of producing too much acid,” said Vishnu Abishek Raju, senior consultant, medical gastroenterology, Apollo Hospitals, Chennai. Heartburn, therefore, is a symptom, rather than a diagnosis. Some people living with reflux have visible inflammation of the oesophagus, while others have symptoms without any visible injury. GERD is common in India. A 2021 analysis of nine Indian studies involving 20,614 people estimated its pooled prevalence at 15.6%.

How reflux occurs

The lower oesophageal sphincter acts as a valve between the oesophagus and stomach. It can undergo brief, inappropriate relaxations, allowing stomach contents to move upwards.

A hiatal hernia can weaken the anti-reflux barrier by allowing part of the stomach to move above the diaphragm. Obesity, particularly excess abdominal fat,



A burning sensation may reflect acid reflux, heightened oesophageal sensitivity or another disorder, and persistent symptoms need to be assessed. GETTY IMAGES

increases pressure within the abdomen, while delayed gastric emptying can increase the volume and pressure inside the stomach.

The oesophagus also has protective mechanisms. Saliva helps clear refluxed material, while alkaline mucus helps limit acid-related injury.

“People may have acid reflux within a stipulated period. But if that goes beyond the protective mechanisms of the body, those defensive mechanisms fail and the food pipe can get damaged, a condition called oesophagitis,” said Arul Prakash, clinical lead and senior consultant in medical gastroenterology, SRM Prime Hospital, Chennai.

The amount of reflux does not always correspond to the severity of symptoms.

“Some people have increased sensitivity of the oesophagus, so even normal amounts of reflux can produce significant burning or chest discomfort,” Dr. Abishek Raju said. This includes reflux hypersensitivity and functional heartburn. In reflux hypersensitivity, symptoms are linked to reflux events despite normal overall reflux exposure. In functional heartburn, symptoms occur without evidence that reflux is responsible.

“These are people who may feel a burning sensation with almost anything they eat because the nerves in the food pipe are very sensitive,” Dr. Arul Prakash said. This is one reason why simply increasing acid-suppressing medicines does not necessarily resolve persistent symptoms.

A response to a proton pump

inhibitor (PPI) can support a diagnosis of GERD, but it does not prove that reflux is the cause.

When symptoms continue despite appropriately used treatment, doctors may need to investigate other causes, including oesophageal motility disorders and disorders of oesophageal sensitivity.

Endoscopy is particularly important when there are alarm symptoms such as difficulty or pain while swallowing, bleeding, unexplained weight loss, persistent vomiting or anaemia. It can detect oesophagitis, ulcers, strictures and Barrett's oesophagus.

A normal endoscopy, however, does not exclude reflux. In such cases, 24-hour pH-impedance monitoring can measure reflux episodes, distinguish acid from non-acid reflux and assess whether symptoms occur in association with reflux.

Lifestyle measures

Weight loss can reduce reflux symptoms in people who are overweight or obese. Avoiding food for about three hours before lying down can help, particularly with night-time symptoms.

Food triggers vary. Rather than eliminating multiple foods routinely, patients should identify those that consistently worsen their symptoms.

(athira.elssa@thehindu.co.in)

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Share of UPI transaction value risks MDR charges

10 in per cent. Only about 10% of the overall value of UPI transactions could face the risk of charges being passed on to consumers under the merchant discount rate (MDR), with large corporates absorbing most of the proposed costs, NPCI chief Dilip Asbe said on Thursday. PTI

New hires by PhonePe to expand merchant network in rural India

20,000 PhonePe said on Thursday it plans to hire 20,000 additional on-roll sales employees over the next year as part of a push to expand its merchant network into India's smaller towns and villages. PTI

Amount to be spent by U.S. Energy Dept. amid skyrocketing demand

2 in \$ billion. The Energy Department is set to announce it will spend almost \$2 billion to try to squeeze more electricity out of the nation's stressed power grid, as President Donald Trump's administration steps up efforts to avoid blackouts amid skyrocketing energy demand spurred by AI. AP

Projects stuck due to court cases, regulatory decisions by J&K govt.

113 As many as 113 development projects worth ₹245 crore in J&K are held up due to court cases and pending decisions, the government said on Thursday. It said the projects were under status quo owing to decisions pending before courts or competent authorities. PTI

Percentage rise in India's tech funding in January-September

7 in per cent. Funding in the Indian technology ecosystem rose 7% year-on-year to \$10.3 billion during the first nine months of 2026, driven by larger deal sizes even as overall deal volumes contracted sharply, said a report by data intelligence platform Tracxn. PTI
COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

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The unbearable burden of freedom

Surinder Koli spent close to 20 years in prison before his convictions in the Nithari cases unravelled and the court acquitted him in 2025; his case shows the structural failure to support wrongfully convicted people after acquittal, including through psychosocial support, housing, employment and monetary assistance

LETTER & SPIRIT

Maitreyi Misra
Anup Surendranath

Surinder Koli was acquitted and released from prison in November 2025 by the Supreme Court after spending close to 20 years in prison, many of which were on death row. On September 18, he was found dead. Although an autopsy is awaited, early news reports described it as a suicide.

Accused of the infamous Nithari cases, at the time of his arrest in 2006 and over the next many years, Koli not only bore the brunt of the criminal justice system but also of wild public allegations. Referred to as 'the butcher of Nithari' and publicly accused of cannibalism, the media dredged up an image of Koli that became a frequent source of material fuelling the 'true crime' genre. Based on snippets from his 'confessions' (later found to be given under torture), the public discourse against Koli was so totalising as to leave no space for uncertainty.

The cases unravelled

Between 2009 and 2022, Koli was found guilty and sentenced to death by the trial court in 13 cases. One by one, the cases against him unravelled, as court after court found that there was no real evidence against him. In several cases, the Allahabad High Court characterised the investigation as botched up and an "easy course of implicating a poor servant of the house by demonising him, without taking due care of probing more serious aspects." When acquitting him in 2025 in the last case, the Supreme Court made it clear that the High Court's comments could not be dismissed as a 'rhetorical excess' and that the evidentiary basis for Koli's conviction was unreliable, inadmissible and in violation of his rights. Yet, Koli came close to being executed in



Surinder Koli. FILE PHOTO

2014. A stay on execution, issued by the Supreme Court just four hours before, averted that fate.

We mention these facts not to relitigate his case, but to remind ourselves of the mourning we owe Koli. He was publicly demonised, and so a public mourning. We remind ourselves of these facts because they also raise a question. What does a justice system owe to a person it has wrongly taken so much from?

For a person like Koli, whose name still conjured a particular and monstrous image, rebuilding his life posed additional challenges. According to news reports, Koli had adopted a different name to secure housing and employment. This may have been because of the stigma associated with his name and his fear of the public's reaction. Even after being acquitted, he was condemned by the same society he had to re-enter. The seriously botched investigation, however, has little bearing on public memory.

A structural failure

Koli's case is not a one-off. India has a serious wrongful convictions problem. An analysis by The Square Circle Clinic of 25 years of data on death sentences shows

that 40% of death sentences imposed by trial courts ultimately result in acquittals by appellate courts. That is a staggering number, made worse by the fact that individuals are made to live under a death sentence even when their convictions are barely sustainable. Once set at liberty, neither the State nor society provides them with adequate support to return and reintegrate, even as we may have subjected them to the full force of our vengeance.

There have been a few instances where the Supreme Court has explicitly recognised such travesties. It has awarded compensation in a few cases and, in 2025, recognised the need for a legislative response to wrongful convictions. But this barely skims the surface of a deep structural problem. As institutions, our prisons are far from being effective in preparing individuals for reintegration into society. Asking a prison to be interested in a category of prisoners the justice system has declared to be executed is being naive about the political and structural reality of our prisons.

These failures, which begin inside prisons, are only compounded outside. Prisoners, particularly those like Koli,

who are released after spending decades incarcerated, have to readjust to a world vastly different from the one they entered when they went to prison. This readjustment involves unlearning, relearning, and learning new things that a person, now much older and unaccustomed to such a stimulating environment, has to undergo. Life has to begin anew with livelihood and housing to be found, and relationships to be re-established. The immense cognitive, emotional, psychological, and physical reorientation required is difficult to imagine.

Beyond acquittal

The eagerness driving our collective retributive instinct appears missing when we are faced with the consequences of that bloodlust. The response to such injustice cannot be ad hoc sympathy but must be structural and underpinned by principles of integrity, accountability and remediation. The integrity of a justice system lies in a meaningful acknowledgement of wrongdoing when the wrong occurs. Psychosocial support to cope with the realities of their new world healthily; safe halfway homes which allow the person to slowly adjust to a constantly changing world; reconnection with the family that they left behind; and monetary support and employment schemes to allow them a chance at independent livelihood must be seen as an inalienable part of a harsh criminal justice system, and at minimum when it exercises its coercive powers wrongfully.

Over the course of 13 acquittals, Koli lost close to 20 years of his life to a justice system that never once acknowledged the harm it caused him. It is unlikely that the injustice to Koli will become the moral reckoning it ought to be. Absent any introspection, we condemn ourselves to see many Kolis.

(The authors are with The Square Circle Clinic, NALSAR University of Law. Views expressed are personal)

THE GIST

▼ The criminal justice system's handling of Koli's case raises questions about accountability when investigations and convictions cause grave harm

▼ Wrongfully convicted people released after prolonged incarceration face immense challenges in readjusting to society and rebuilding their lives

▼ The State's response to wrongful convictions must go beyond compensation or ad hoc sympathy to include meaningful acknowledgement, accountability and measures for rehabilitation and reintegration

What are the alternatives to the SWIFT payment system?

Why are countries looking beyond SWIFT? How are CIPS, SPFS and mBridge faring?

G R Rajeev

The story so far:

The New Delhi Declaration that came out of the recent BRICS Summit in the National Capital resolved to increase trade between member-countries and payments in national currencies. Days before the summit, a report by the news agency Reuters quoted sources as saying that at the event, India would push to link central bank digital currencies (CBDCs) for cross-border payments across BRICS nations, despite political and technical hurdles that could limit progress. The proposal to link CBDCs would be part of the agenda for the leaders' meeting, the sources said, though the limited adoption of digital currencies globally could complicate implementation, the report added. The proposal was, however, not part of the Declaration.

Multiple wars and U.S. weaponisation of the dollar through financial sanctions are making countries in the Global South

think of bypassing the so-far universally accepted Belgium-based SWIFT system for inter-country payments. The attempts to do so have been patchy, but there is an increasingly felt need to have other options.

What are some of the alternatives to the SWIFT payment system?

Project mBridge is a group comprising the Bank of Thailand, the Central Bank of the United Arab Emirates, the Digital Currency Institute of the People's Bank of China, the Hong Kong Monetary Authority, and the Saudi Central Bank.

The Cross-Border Interbank Payment System (CIPS), a Reuters report said, is backed by the People's Bank of China. China launched the CIPS clearing and settlement services system in 2015 to internationalise yuan use. It allows global banks to clear cross-border yuan transactions directly onshore, instead of through clearing banks in offshore yuan hubs, the report said.

The System for Transfer of Financial

Messages, or SPFS, was developed by Russia in 2014 to bypass Western sanctions. In 2022, Russian banks were cut off from SWIFT, and the SPFS was of help.

SEPAMA, Iran's local interbank telecom system, has as many as 52 branches of Iranian banks and four unnamed foreign banks connecting with 106 banks using the SPFS, the Central Bank of Iran said in 2023.

How are these systems faring?

The Bank for International Settlements (BIS), an international financial institution owned by central banks to foster international monetary and financial cooperation, exited Project mBridge on October 31, 2024, after hand-holding it since 2019, when the Hong Kong Monetary Authority and the Bank of Thailand launched the system. The mBridge, a cross-bloc multi-CBDC platform with no Western bank, attained minimum viability status in 2024. It was envisaged for direct peer-to-peer CBDC

settlement without going through correspondent banks. The project team developed a new blockchain – the mBridge Ledger – custom-built by central banks to serve as a specialised and flexible platform for implementation of multi-currency cross-border payments in CBDCs, the BIS website says.

The BIS's exit came under a cloud, with media reports saying it was because mBridge could provide the basis for a BRICS initiative to circumvent sanctions on Russia. A May 2016 Forbes report said that by late 2025, mBridge was in practice "a renminbi-denominated wholesale settlement rail for trade between China and the Gulf, running outside the dollar correspondent system".

The renminbi's inclusion in the basket of currencies making up the Special Drawing Right, an international reserve asset created by the International Monetary Fund, has increased the acceptance of CIPS, said a November 2025 opinion piece in The Hindu by Biswajit Dhar, a trade economist and former professor at Jawaharlal Nehru University. The CIPS now has participants in more than 120 countries, including all BRICS members except India.

A South China Morning Post report says CIPS processed 679.8 billion yuan of transactions on average per day in 2025. "While the CIPS has gained ground, it remains far smaller in scale than established global systems, such as the U.S.-based Clearing House Interbank Payments System," it said. Beijing now

appears to be moving towards building CIPS into a global platform compliant with multi-currency settlements and other foreign payment channels, the report quoted a study led by Ju Jiandong, a chair professor at Tsinghua University's PBC School of Finance.

The SPFS, formed as Russian entities were banned from SWIFT, has grown at a record pace in 2023 as Moscow ramped up efforts to resolve financial shortcomings wrought by sanctions over the Ukraine war. Alla Bakina, director of the Russian central bank's national payment system department, said 50 new entities joined Russia's alternative system in 2023, taking the total to 440, of which more than 100 are non-residents.

How do India-Russia trade settlements happen now?

Russia and India, the second-largest importer of Russian oil, have built a functioning payments infrastructure using roubles and rupees, which now account for 96% of bilateral trade, Ivan Nosov, head of Sberbank in India, said. "I am ready to say that this is one of the best-established mechanisms for Russia's payments with other countries," he said.

According to official data, 22 Russian banks, including Sberbank, Russia's largest lender, which was tasked with developing the payments infrastructure, and 17 Indian banks are currently servicing bilateral trade, a Reuters report said.

